

ב"ה

ראש

השנה

ה'תשע"ב

ספ

יום ראשון

Note from the compiler:

Elul 5771

Dear Fellow Shliach,

Several years ago, I came to realization that the average person attending our high holiday services was not having the most fulfilling experience possible. The majority of people at my services were typical American Jews who appear at a synagogue two or three times a year. These wonderful Jews, while understanding the need to be in Shul during the high holy days, do not read or understand Hebrew nor are they familiar with the concept of davening. It dawned upon me that I had a unique responsibility to make these few hours as meaningful as possible and hopefully ignite the “pinteleh yid” thus encouraging more frequent participation at our Chabad events during the rest of the year.

Thus began the “rabbi’s talking points and prayer guide”. These notes are meant to infuse a potentially confusing experience with meaningful insight and clear prayer direction. All of the talking points contained herein are culled from various sources. This year marks the 8<sup>th</sup> of this compilation.

Page numbers correspond to both the new and old Kehot machzorim: the first number represents the old and the second one the new. This guide outlines select prayers which are said out loud in English, while others are sung together in Hebrew. Occasionally, you can ask a member of the congregation to share a prayer with everyone else.

Throughout these pages are icons that represent important points:

-  Announcement for the Rabbi
-  Prayer Insight
-  Chazzan Interaction
-  Humorous point

Typically, the rabbi should daaven beforehand which will allow him to speak freely the entire time. In order to make the guide easy to follow, every talking point and step of the service that is performed as a congregation is numbered and the rabbi moves forward from number to number as the services progress. The chazzan works together with the rabbi coordinating the services appropriately. He recites all the tefilos and will sing the central ones out loud. While the rabbi delivers a talking point, he continues quietly.

It is self understood that no two congregations are alike. What may work at one may not necessarily be appropriate for another. For some, reciting tefilos in English may not be a good idea while for others more singing should be instituted. Ultimately, it is the responsibility of every Shliach to gauge the needs of his community and adapt accordingly.

I hope that you find this compilation helpful.

With wishes for a כתיבה וחתימה טובה

Rabbi Simcha Backman  
Glendale, California

## **Rosh Hashanah Shacharis**

### **Introduction to Rosh Hashanah Prayers**

Rosh Hashana, "The New Year" in Hebrew, is a deeply spiritual holiday. The New Year commemorates the creation of the world (Adam and Eve were created on Rosh Hashana) and each year the world's existence is extended for another year, created anew, as it were. Mankind is also included in this new creation every year.

The New Year is an obvious time for judgment (which is why Rosh Hashana is also called Yom HaDin, literally "Judgment Day"). Every creation we make, whether it is in art, business or even cooking, is judged by us. At some point we will step back and evaluate our creation. Does it live up to expectations? Are we pleased with it? What are its faults? On this, the anniversary of our creation, God does the same with us. We are evaluated, hence the "Day of Judgment".

This day is deeply spiritual because on judgment day, not unlike what happens when a person is waiting to hear a court sentence, we are forced to reflect on ourselves. Did I live up to God's expectation of me? Is God pleased with me? What are my faults? Because of the intense mood of the moment this day presents the most powerful spiritual opportunity available -- the opportunity for us to reflect on how we can elevate ourselves to a higher plane. What does God want from me? He wants me to be on His team. How am I judged? Have I lived my year pursuing self-gratification, or have I grown closer to God in thought and deed? Am I making this world a better place to live in?

This is the judgment on Rosh Hashana, these are the questions, and with this understanding the opportunities for spiritual growth are unparalleled. Dig in and enjoy the potential. Rosh Hashana is the spiritual world's prime time.

### **Lost in the Synagogue?**

The Rosh Hashana liturgy represents some of the most sublime and awesome words that have ever been penned to express our love and reverence for God. The theme of the day is making God a King. When we proclaim God as King we formally declare that we are His subjects and that we are at His service to do our part to help make the world a worthwhile creation. But getting into the deeply majestic liturgy is often not so easy. It is not unlike learning to appreciate fine wine or art. It takes time to appreciate rich elegance. Therefore we offer a few suggestions for overcoming possible boredom. Read the introductions and overviews presented in most Rosh Hashana prayer books. It's okay to not follow the services at all times and to do some independent learning and praying.

Use some of the time in shul for reflection and introspection. Tune in to the message of the day and try to meditate on it, letting it permeate your heart in the deepest and truest way. That may be more relevant for you than saying any particular paragraph.

While praying, focus on quality rather than quantity, on depth rather than breadth. Find a portion that you find relevant and meaningful, and say it slowly, thoughtfully. Three recommended portions would include the Shema prayer or Nishmas (just before Shachris Shema) and of course the core of the prayers, the Shemoneh Esrei or Amidah.. Savor the words as you say them, open your heart to their content and message. These are the high points of the service and might be just right for your personal meditations and concentration.

If the original Hebrew is not familiar to you, then have an English translation in the Kehot Machzor.

### Why is it so important to be here today in a Synagogue?

There is undoubtedly great reward for prayer even at home, but when one joins with the community in communal worship our prayers are especially cherished by God. For us, it establishes our dedication to the community and its values. Being together with fellow Jews on Rosh Hashana is its own reward. Maybe your grandchildren will remain Jewish because of your connection to the community.

### What about the Shofar?

The main theme of the day is brought out by the blowing of the shofar. The shofar is the royal trumpet we Jews blast to proclaim God's Kingship. Those blasts have the incredible ability to go deep into places in our psyche that are otherwise dormant and to awaken within them the natural desire to come close to God, to elevate Him, to develop a relationship with Him. The shofar trumpets our coronation of God and awakens our very spiritual essence to perform that job.

Rosh Hashana is a day packed with so much intense opportunity and spiritual promise. It is a day to be cherished. But it often takes some time to develop appreciation for its loftiness. That is why we should take it slow when getting into it at the beginning. Make it a point to focus your energies on a few good growth opportunities for the day and the coming year. In time these few items will become a real treasure trove. And it usually happens much quicker than you think!

We will be expounding on this concept later on in the day.

1. Page 66/85

שיר למעלות

*Recite in English*



*Hodu - According to some Jewish Scholars this prayer is the oldest, continuously said, component of our daily prayers. It has been recited for some 3000 years by the Kohanim even before construction of the Temple, then subsequently by the general Jewish population and it was eventually incorporated into the Ashkenazik prayer book and then adopted by Sefardic Jews.*

Hodu ("give thanks") is the official beginning of the "Verses of Praise," and it is here that we ascend to the second rung on the ladder of prayer. This second segment of the prayer corresponds in Kabbalah to the world of formation (yetzirah), and the level of soul known as ruach, which means "spirit" and signifies emotional consciousness.

In this segment of prayer, we continually praise God for the revelation within nature and within history, for the wonders of creation, and for the miracles performed throughout the ages. These verses of praises were instituted for two primary reasons: first of all, to emulate the prayers of Moshe, who first praised God, then asked for his needs. By evoking Moshe's prayers, our own prayers are thus assisted. And secondly, by praising God, we are inspired and brought into the requisite state of joy.

Overall, this part of prayer is meant to be joyful and recited with an openness of heart. Whereas the word zimra is translated as "praise," it is also related to zemer meaning to "uproot/cut off." In these prayers, we cut away all our wrong desires and chip away at negativity. Yet, in so doing, we do not mean to expunge desire itself, rather to change its trajectory—that is, praise of God inspires a radical reorientation of our entire emotional reality.

2. Page 68/87      הודו לה'      Sing in Hebrew

3. Page 69/89      האדרת      Sing in Hebrew



Baruch Sheamar - this prayer is attributed to the men of the great assembly (Sanhedrin). According to tradition it was revealed from heaven with eighty seven words that correspond to the numerical value of the Hebrew word PAZ meaning "Refined Gold"

This blessing serves as an opening for the "Verses of Praise" (Pesukei De'Zimra). In the following passages of praise, we tell of the greatness of the Creator and the way He is manifest within creation, with the aim of arousing our emotions.

As an initiation to these verses, we recite "Blessed is He Who spoke..." (Baruch Sheamar), a prayer which expresses the wonder and awe of creation and how it is continually being recreated by Divine word.

Although creation had a beginning, it is continuous. God creates and recreates this world anew with each moment. This is an empowering thought to contemplate—that each moment gives us an opportunity to return to God in teshuvah, to start anew no matter what our previous errors were.

Thus, the first letters of the opening words Baruch Sheamar V'haya Ha'olam ("Blessed is He Who spoke and the world came into being")—beit, shin, vav, hei—spell out "return." We can only return to God through teshuvah if we are fully aware of the continuous renewal of creation. This gives us hope. If time would only flow linearly, then the past would inevitably dictate the present and future, and there would be no hope for us. But, when we are aware of the continuous flow of creation—that each moment represents a fresh beginning—we can pray with unimpaired joy.

Baruch Sheamar contains 87 words, which is the numerical value of the word paz, meaning "pure gold." As it says in Psalms (21:4): "You set on his head a crown of pure gold (paz)." This, then, is a prayer of the finest quality, and it is also the golden crown of the entire Pesukei De'Zimra.

The word baruch ("bless") appears thirteen times in this prayer. The number 13, the numerical value of echad (meaning "one"), inspires us to realize the oneness, uniformity and harmony within nature.

✍ During this prayer we gather together the two front fringes of our prayer shawl (tzitzit), an action which evokes the Source of all blessings, God. God's essential four-letter name—spelled yud, hei, vav, hei—has the numerical value of 26. Each corner fringe of the prayer shawl has 8 strings and 5 knots, adding up to 13, and when we gather the two front fringes together, we hold 26.

#### 4. Page 70/89

ברוך שאמר

Recite in English



*Mizmor Shir - Shabbat & Teshuvah - The Midrash tells us that following the brutal murder of his brother Hevel, Kayin was summoned to the heavenly tribunal for judgment. After a brief deliberation, it was decreed that Kayin would be condemned to a life of wandering: "You shall become a vagrant and wanderer on earth." Acknowledging the gravity of his iniquities and accepting his sentence, Kayin beseeched the court for mercy, asking, "Is my iniquity too great to be borne?"*

*Upon leaving the heavenly court, Kayin was met by Adam, his father. Seeing his son's jubilant disposition, Adam inquired of Kayin as to what had occurred in the court. When Kayin told him what he had done and that he had left the court with a clean slate, Adam said, "Such is the power of teshuvah, and I did not know it." He then began to sing "a Psalm, a Song for Shabbat day." The amazing transformative potential of teshuvah aroused Adam to compose a song in honor of the sacred day of Shabbat.*

*Shabbat and teshuvah are both similar in that they are both liberating agents. They spiritually free the human being from the normal course of unfolding reality. Shabbat exists as a refuge in time—no matter how absorbed we may be during the course of the week, we have a sacred time of refuge, when we are able to rest and reflect. Teshuvah is a refuge in place for the soul.*

*If we have drifted away from God and become alienated from the true source of our soul, teshuvah gives us a space where we can find refuge. In this space we can redefine and recreate our inner self and become reborn once again.*



*In Ashrei we find the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet encoded in the prayer. The first letter in each of the first 22 words is the alphabet in its correct order. Because the Hebrew letters are actual instruments of creation, this prayer helps to inject order and power into our lives. We can gain control over our world by tapping the forces that created it. Interestingly, the only letter left out of this prayer is the "nun". King David wisely left it out since nun has the same numeric value as the Hebrew word for falling... "noflim"... falling refers to a spiritual decline. Feelings of doubt, depression, worry, and uncertainty are consequences of spiritual falling.*

*"Happy are they who dwell in Your house and praise You continually..." From this verse (of Psalm 85:5), the Talmudic sages found support for the proper preparation for prayer: first settle the minds and then pray. First dwell in the home then offer praise. (Tosefos, Berachos 32b)*

*This introduction is then followed by Psalm 145. According to the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 4b), any individual who recites this Psalm three times daily is certain to experience the World to Come. For this reason it is included in the prayers three times, twice in the morning prayers, and once in the afternoon prayers.*

*By meditating on the meaning of its verses, we are assured of being strengthened in our belief and resolve, and because of that, we will inherit life in a future world.*

*This Psalm contains all the letters of the Hebrew alphabet except the letter nun, which is the first letter of nefilah, meaning "downfall" (as in the downfall of the nation of Israel) on a collective and individual level into the trap of worry, doubt, uncertainty.*

*Additionally, the nun refers to the mystery of the fallen Shechinah—the Presence of God, which is in exile now, as we read in the Book of Amos (9:11) "the canopy of David that is falling"—falling now. What we need to do is elevate the Shechinah, and bring about the unification between the higher spiritual world and the lower physical world.*

*This is why this Psalm opens with: "A Psalm of praise by David: I will elevate You," meaning "I will elevate/lift up the Shechinah." And this we do by offering praise to God.*

## 5. Talking Point #1

### The Master Key - A Broken Heart

One year, Rabbi Yisrael Ba'al Shem Tov said to Rabbi Ze'eiv Kitzes, one of his senior disciples, "You will sound the shofar for us this Rosh Hashanah. I want you to study all the kavanot (kabbalistic meditations) that pertain to shofar, so that you should meditate upon them when you do the Shofar sounding."

Rabbi Ze'eiv applied himself to the task with joy and trepidation: joy over the great privilege that had been accorded him, and trepidation over the immensity of the responsibility. He studied the kabbalistic writings that discuss the multifaceted significance of the shofar and what its sounds achieve. He also prepared a sheet of paper on which he noted the main points of each kavanah so that he could refer to them when he sounded the shofar.

Finally, the great moment arrived. It was the morning of Rosh Hashanah, and Rabbi Ze'eiv stood on the bimah - reading platform - in the center of the Ba'al Shem Tov's synagogue amidst the Torah scrolls, surrounded by a sea of tallit-draped bodies. At his table in the southeast corner of the room stood his master, the Ba'al Shem Tov, his face aflame. An awed silence filled the room in anticipation of the climax of the day - the piercing blasts and sobs of the shofar.

Rabbi Ze'eiv reached into his pocket and his heart froze: The paper had disappeared! He distinctly remembered placing it there that morning, but now it was gone. Furiously, he searched his memory for what he had learned, but his distress over the lost notes seemed to have incapacitated his brain: His mind was a total blank. Tears of frustration filled his eyes. He had disappointed his master, who had entrusted him with this most sacred task. He had to sound the shofar like a simple horn, without any kavanot. With a despairing heart, Rabbi Ze'eiv blew the sounds required by halachah, and avoiding his master's eye, resumed his place.

At the conclusion of the day's prayers, the Ba'al Shem Tov made his way to the corner where Rabbi Ze'eiv sat sobbing under his tallit. "Gut Yom Tov, Reb Ze'eiv!" he called, "That was a most extraordinary shofar sounding we heard today!"

"But Rebbe...Why...?"

"In the king's palace," said Rabbi Yisrael, "There are many gates and doors, leading to many halls and chambers. The palace keepers have great rings holding many keys, each of which opens a different door. But there is a master key that opens all the doors. The kavanot are keys, each unlocks a door and accesses another chamber in the supernal worlds. But there is one key which unlocks all doors and which can open the innermost chambers of the Divine palace. That master key is a broken heart."

☺ *A community was asked about the qualities of their former rabbi. "He can be compared to Moses, King David, and an angel," came the response.*

*With such words of praise, the new community eagerly accepted the rabbi as their new spiritual leader, but, alas they quickly realized he was incapable of anything. He was a rotten apple.*

*They wrote a letter to the other community, complaining as to why they deceived them.*

*To which they received a reply, "We were not deceiving you. Just like Moses-this rabbi can't really speak. He knows not a word of English-like King David. And just as an angel -- a mentsh he is not."*

📖 *Nishmas – Our complete dependency on God is described in this moving and beautiful prayer. We again express praise and gratitude to God for all he has done for us. In this outpouring of praise we exclaim, "Were our mouths as full of song as the sea is of water and our tongues as full of joyous song as its multitude of waves..."*

6. Page 77/97

נשמת

Recite in English

📖 *Hamelech – The theme of Rosh Hashana is Kabbolas Ol, accepting upon ourselves God as our King. This acceptance is different than the daily acceptance of God being our creator. On a daily basis the kabbolas Ol functions as a foundation and beginning to our day, but the day itself is independent from its foundation. On Rosh Hashannah, the Kabbolas Ol is the essence of the day. Without it there is no day, and there is no foundation. – Lubavitcher Rebbe*

7. Page 81/99

שוכן עד

Recite in English

📖 *Yishtabach - there are 15 expressions of praises to G-d in this paragraph, similar to the 15 steps in the Temple in Jerusalem. Our relationship with God must be handled as we deal with life, one step at a time. Each step is a message that moulds and shapes our character. Similarly, our relationship with God is multifaceted, subtle, and sublime.*

The verses of praise, Pesukei De'Zimra, began with a blessing (Baruch Sheamar) and concludes with a blessing (Yishtabach), even if this final blessing does not begin in the standard manner of "Blessed are You..." (Baruch Ata).

After singing God's praises for the wonders of continued creation and the miracle of the splitting of the sea, we conclude with the words, Yachid, Chei Ha'olamim, meaning "Unified, the Life of [all] the worlds."

There are two ways in which we speak of God as the life force. One is to say that God is Chei Ha'olamim and the other is Chai Ha'olamim. While both are translated in English as "Life of the worlds." In Hebrew, there is a subtle difference between the two. The word chei is a descriptive phrase, meaning "life of..." But the word chai is a noun, meaning "life." Thus, when it refers to God, chei denotes the "Life force of the world"—that light that is connected to, and permeates, this universe. Chai, on the other hand, denotes the light that is transcendent, hovering above the world.

Having explored nature and the miracles of nature, we come to an awareness that both the immanent light and the transcendent light are manifestations of one unified light, reflecting the finite and the infinite.

8. Page 81/100

ישתבח

Recite in English



Shir Hamaalos - written by King David, this prayer evokes forgiveness and supplication. It opens with "from the depth of my heart I call to you" – our prayers to God need to come from deep within; a service of the heart and soul

9. Page 81/100

שיר המעלות

Recite in English



Kaddish - In the prayer service, whenever there is a change between prayers, a break or movement, a special prayer called a kaddish ("sanctification" of the name of God) is recited in order to bring unity.

Whenever there is a separation in the prayers—or for that matter a "break" in life itself—we recite the Kaddish and declare, "Magnified and sanctified may His great name be..." Thus, we ensure that His name, the Source of all, is brought together in harmony, and a healing on all levels of existence takes place.

The essential four-letter name of God—spelled in Hebrew yud-hei-vav-hei—can be viewed as containing two parts. The first yud-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 15, represents the spiritual transcendence; the second vav-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 11, represents the physical immediate. This separation is the root cause of all dissension and separations, death included.

By reciting the Kaddish, "yisgadal veyiskadash," which contains eleven letters, we reunify the name and inspire a total reunification of the entire world.

10. Page 82/101

ברכו

Recite in Hebrew



Barchu - The Zohar teaches that "all things holy need summoning." And so the leader of the prayers begins with, "Bless God!," calling the entire congregation to bless God, adding, "Who is blessed" so as to include himself within the community. The congregation responds with, "Blessed be God," adding "Who is

blessed forever and ever," implying that God is blessed by all—the lowly creatures and the heavenly, above and below.

The five Hebrew words of the response correspond to the five levels of soul, which become fully integrated by the reciting of the blessing.

☞ We bend our knees and bow saying these words as we become open to God's blessings by humbling ourselves. The word for "bless" (barchu) shares its root with the word for "knee" (beirach), and so we bend our knees as we open ourselves to receive God's blessings.

11. Page 85/104

קדוש – ברוך

Recite in Hebrew



#### Ahavas Olam - Unity through Humility

Ahavas Olam is a prayer for unity. When we say, "bring us in peace from the four corners of the earth," we gather the four fringes (tzitzit) from the four corners of the prayer shawl (talit). In absolute reality, there is total unity, but in our world, there seems to be disharmony and division. There are corners/parts to the world. And so, we take the four fringes, which have 32 strings, and bring them together as one, holding them in the left hand and placing them against the heart for the reading of the Shema.

The number 32 denotes the paths of chochmah ("wisdom") and the idea of bitul ("self-nullification"), which open us up to a higher reality. By bringing the 32 strings together, we evoke the power of chochmah and the idea of bitul-ego abandonment, and through that, we bring peace, harmony, and unity to our own microcosmic world and to the macrocosmic world of which we are a part.

The talit together with its tzitzit embraces both unity and diversity. The multiplicity is represented by the fringes on the corners, but the fact that they are part of one garment represents the interconnectedness between all the apparent separate forces. Bringing the corners together as one, we are ready for the Shema—the quintessential statement of God's oneness.

12. Page 86/104

אבינו – והאר

Sing in Hebrew



The Shema is the ultimate expression of Divine unity. It declares not only that there is one God, but that there is nothing else other than God. God is one and the same as He was before and after the creation of the world, and all that exists is included within God.

The recitation of the Shema is commanded by the Torah, and ought to be done with complete and undivided attention since it expresses the basic principle of Torah—the belief in Divine oneness—and it speaks of the Creator's relationship with humanity and with our evolving history.

Generally, the Shema is said out loud with the right hand lightly covering the eyes, in order to block out any extraneous distractions, and to help us go inward.

The Shema, says the Talmud, should be recited in "the language you hear," meaning the language you "know." This mandate also suggests that whatever you hear—in everything and through everything that you hear—you should sense Divine oneness.

Two letters of the Shema are written extra large in a Torah scroll: the ayin, the last letter of the word Shema ("hear") and the dalet, the last letter of the word echad ("one"). Taken together, these two letters spell aid, meaning "witness." By reciting the Shema, we bear witness to the Creator's oneness.

When the final word, echad, is pronounced, it is drawn out, with each letter distinctly audible. These letters are: alef (which has the numerical value of 1), chet (8), dalet (4). Accordingly, when pronouncing these letters, we should think about the oneness of the Creator permeating the eight levels of creation (the seven heavens and the earth), and the four corners or four dimensions of the world, thus making ourselves aware that all dimensions, as well as time and space, are included in the unity of the Creator. There is also a custom among some when pronouncing echad to move the head slightly—right, left, forward, back, down and up—to indicate that the oneness of God permeates all directions of creation.

The Zohar mentions that when we pronounce the word echad, we should meditate on being willing to give up our life for God, even imagining ourselves being consumed by fire, thus sanctifying God's name.

Symbolically, when we cover our eyes, we are momentarily, technically blind, and as "the blind is akin to the dead," so the covering the eyes suggest a death of a sort—a rapture, a state of ecstasy, an expiration of the soul. In the words of Rabbi Eliezer Ezkari, it is as if "one died and is in front of the King."

In the opening statement of the Shema, plus the short statement that follows (Baruch Sheim), there are 49 letters, corresponding to the 49 gates of understanding, indicating that these passages of the Shema need to be absorbed intellectually, emotionally and ultimately factually.

✍ It is customary to cover our eyes with our right hand while reciting the first verse, to promote deep concentration.

13. Page 86/105

שמע

Recite in Hebrew

14. Page 89/108

מי כמוך

Sing in Hebrew



This prayer is called the "Amidah" the "standing" prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.

The Amidah is the central part of the service, it's said every day of the year. It's divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.

**Praise:** The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.

**Petition:** The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.

**Thanksgiving:** Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.

The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another

blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before God. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to God) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with God in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that Godliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

### Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter God's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) loud and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.



*Repetition of the Amidah – Remember us for life, King who desires life; inscribe us in the book of life, for our sake, O living God – four types of life. The word life is mentioned four times, corresponding to the four letters in God's most holy name, Yud, Hei, Vav and Hei. Additionally, these four repetitions of life correspond to the four spiritual worlds known as Atzilus (world of closeness), Briah (world of creation), Yezirah (world of formation) and Asiyah (world of action). Another four corrections are: this world, the world to come, the days of Moshiach and the resurrection of the dead. – Siddur HaRid*

15. Page 95/115

מסוד

Recite in English

16. Page 97/118

זכרון

Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English



*Zachreinu L'Chaim – During the recitation of the Amidah between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there are additions in the prayers.*

*This short addition called zahrienu or "remember us" contains the unholy number of eleven words signifying the eradication of forgetfulness. The holy number is ten, as in the Ten Sefirot (the ten spheres/channels of Divine energy through which God created the vessels of this world and which continue to permeate all existence).*

*In the holy (kedusha), there is a full integration of the Divine light within the vessels; however, in the unholy (kelipa), the Divine light does not fully permeate the vessel and remains detached and separate. Therefore, there are ten vessels plus the light, comprising the number eleven.*

*In the world of kedusha, which signifies full integration, there is no forgetfulness. In fact, there is no lapse of time, as all time is one unified whole. It is a world of no separation, and thus the past is as present as the future. It is only in the realm of kelipa, a world of separation and disunity, that the past becomes separate from the present and future, and there is forgetfulness.*

*Further on in Amidah, we continue with references to memory. Before "Who revives the dead," we add "Who is like You..." This short prayer contains eight words, as the number eight represents the transcendent—that which is above the natural cycle of created reality, represented by the number seven (as in the seven days of the week). Eight is beyond time. In recognition of this fact, the High Priest would also wear eight garments, thus unifying all time with the place of Divine mercy.*

## 17. Talking Point #2

Can we be optimistic about the coming New Year?

What a year we've just lived through!

So many things went wrong. The economy went into crisis mode. Our retirement funds dwindled in value and jobs became scarcer. Mother Nature took it out on us with a vengeance, smiting us with hurricanes, earthquakes and unbearable temperatures. Rebellions and revolutions spread around the globe and the vision of universal peace realistically seemed further away than ever.

And with all that came a visible cultural change that we can't remember afflicting us any time in the past.

Peggy Noonan captured it precisely in a perceptive article she wrote in the Wall Street Journal. She put it this way: "The biggest political change in my lifetime is that Americans no longer assume that their children will have it better than they did ... the country I was raised in was a country that had existed steadily, for almost two centuries, as a nation in which everyone thought – wherever they were from, whatever their circumstances – that their children would have better lives than they did. That was what kept people pulling their boots on in the morning after the first weary pause: my kids will have it better... Parents now fear something has stopped ... our view of the future is now fundamentally pessimistic."

Till now the American spirit was defined by optimism. The American dream was built on the hope for a constantly improving future. Growth, prosperity and ever greater success were assumed almost as if they were part of our deserved birthright.

Every new year could be counted on to be better than the one before.

But that's no longer true.

As we carry on our annual tradition to wish each other a happy new year before this Rosh Hashanah, we have to stop and wonder whether this time the greeting is unrealistic. Can we, should we, really expect happy times ahead? In times such as these, is it rational to still be optimistic?

The answer I believe is that it isn't simply permissible to be an optimist, it's a mitzvah and it's mandatory!

### **Is God an Optimist?**

Which of the two is the Creator of the universe—an optimist or a pessimist? If we believe the words of the Bible, all we have to do is look at the opening chapter. Every day God created something different and then He figuratively stepped back to evaluate what He had brought into being. What He saw pleased Him greatly, and from day to day he gave His verdict that “it was good.” Then, when He finally completed His work with the creation of Adam and Eve, the Bible tells us, “And God saw everything that He had made, and, behold, it was very good” (Genesis 1:31).

That's why William James, the American psychologist and philosopher, was right when he said that, “Pessimism is essentially a religious disease.” A pessimist disagrees with divine judgment. A pessimist believes that we live in the worst of all possible worlds. Too bad he doesn't take seriously the opinion of the One who made it!

Psychologist Martin Seligman, of the University of Pennsylvania, concluded that pessimism can be changed; people can alter their thinking about bad events and thereby improve their health.

Many health professionals have come to agree with him; optimism can be cultivated. Robert Thayer, a professor of psychology at California State University, Long Beach, in his book *The Origin of Everyday Moods*, says that most people erroneously think of optimism and pessimism as fixed traits. But he and his colleagues find that these feelings even in one and the same person tend to come and go. They are like moods that usually are associated with specific moments.

Even when the world around us seems to be crashing and our lives filled with forebodings of disaster, there are ways to prevent ourselves from falling into depression and from assuming that God has forsaken us.

Following are some helpful tips in keeping your focus positive:

- Helping others helps considerably to build optimism. It seems that loving your neighbor as yourself isn't just good for your neighbor; it's a powerful medicine for you as well. Optimists discover that cooperation is better than competition.
- Concentrate on what you want in life, not on what you don't want. Optimists focus on solutions rather than problems. In other words, they switch from thinking, "I hate my boss," to "What can I do to become a better person?"
- Spending time with constant complainers will influence your thinking. Having friends who enjoy life and laugh often will do wonders for your disposition. Developing a sense of community by joining a church or synagogue and strengthening positive values creates a totally different inner world, no matter how bad external events appear.
- Learn to use upbeat language. Never say you're tired. Just tell people you need to recharge your batteries. Best of all use prayer to highlight your connection with a higher power and your continued hope for the future.
- Choose how we think, styles of thinking become habits. We can control our thoughts as we can our muscles. Pessimists tend to have hopeless thoughts. They tell themselves, "I'll never get it right," or "I always screw up," or worse, they stamp themselves with a negative label: "I must be stupid." People have to learn to speak to themselves more kindly, the way you would expect a loving friend to do. If you acted like a jerk, don't give yourself that description in your own mind, but say, "Sometimes I'm not as considerate as I'd like to be, but overall I know I'm a kind person." This echoes the profound admonition of the Chafetz Chaim, who warned that it is just as sinful to speak ill of oneself as it is to speak badly of others.
- Accept the fact that human beings can alter their lives by altering their attitudes of mind. Concentration camp survivors often explain that their most important strategy for staying alive was imagining in their minds eating an entire meal, from appetizer to dessert. They didn't get any calories but they did affirm their confidence that some day their lives would be normal again. Let the mind think holy thoughts, Jewish sages long ago counseled, and that is how you become holy.
- Learn to look at people and think of their positive qualities rather than their faults. If the first thing you notice about your date is that he's bald but don't even see his beautiful

smile and his kindly face, you're probably doomed to a life of loneliness because nobody is good enough for you.

- And most important of all, attach yourself to a belief system that inspires and gives meaning to your life - a spiritual boost that will ensure happiness regardless of trying circumstances.

What all these insightful ideas share in common is that we owe it to ourselves to be optimistic no matter what goes on around us - and that the spiritual values of faith have the greatest potential to achieve that goal.

All this is another way of saying that when we rededicate ourselves to God on the High Holy Days we stand the greatest chance of ensuring that - in spite of everything - we will have a very happy new year.

☺ *Ruth is visiting the shopping center when she meets Esther. It's the first time they've met since leaving school and they quickly get talking.*

*Ruth says, "You were always so well organized in school, Esther, so I'm wondering, are you now living the well planned life you always said you would?"*

*"Oh yes Ruth, I certainly am," replies Esther. "My first marriage was to a multi-millionaire property developer; my second marriage was to a West End musical star; my third marriage was to Rabbi Levy, and at present I'm married to the chairman of The United Synagogue Burial Society."*

*"But I don't understand, Esther," says Ruth. "What on earth do your marriages have to do with a well-planned life?"*

*"Well it's easy really," replies Esther. "It's .... One for the Money, Two for the Show, Three to get Ready, and Four to Go."*

📖 *Atoh Hu -This alphabetically arranged piyut describes the power and sovereignty of God. Rosh Hashanah is dedicated to the proclamation that God is our King and He is righteous and fair, close to all who sincerely call on Him.*

18. Page 98/118

אתה הוא

*Recite in English*

19. 🎵 Page 98/118

אתה הוא

TTO: Carlebach מזמור לדוד

📖 *Loeil Orech Din - This alphabetically arranged piyut is really a continuation of the previous piyut. It praises the attributes of God as He sits in judgment and is filled with forgiveness, compassion and mercy. Every first half-line ends with the words B'yom Din ("on the day of judgment") the other half-line ends with the word Badin ("with judgment"). The poem is changed with intense feeling, so that we can loudly and communally proclaim each of God's attributes.*

|                     |               |                                  |
|---------------------|---------------|----------------------------------|
| 20. 🎵 Page 98/118   | שמו מפארים    | TTO: עולם                        |
| 21. 🎵 Page 99/119   | אדר והוד      | TTO: צור משלו                    |
| 22. 🎵 Page 101/ 121 | אדירי איומה   | TTO: אשרי                        |
| 23. Page 105/125    | לא-ל עורך דין | <i>Recite in English</i>         |
| 24. 🎵 Page 105/125  | לא-ל עורך דין | TTO: The Little Bird or אשא עיני |

📖 *Kedusha – The children of Israel join the angels in praising God in this most significant part of the Cantor's repetition which is the sanctification of God's name in the highest heavens. In the book of Ezekiel we find that the angles who surround God keep their feet together when going before God. We do the same for this prayer.*

|                   |            |                          |
|-------------------|------------|--------------------------|
| 25. Page 106/126  | נקדישך     | <i>Recite in Hebrew</i>  |
| 26. Page 107/ 127 | אתה בחרתנו | <i>Sing in Hebrew</i>    |
| 27. Page 110/132  | ובספר חיים | <i>Recite in English</i> |

📖 *Oseh HA'Shalom - Before we conclude the Amidah we take three steps backward, taking the intense energy that was present during our prayers and bringing it down into this world—into the three levels of creation (beriah), formation (yetzira) and action (asiya). Thus, we integrate and tie up our prayers so that there is no nourishment for the unholy from this holy place of prayer. Occasionally, the intensity of a spiritual experience can spill over into unwanted directions, and so we need to make sure that there is no such thing happening here.*

*As we recite the words ose shalom ("make peace...") we bow to the right, left and center, bringing peace to the entire world.*

*During the days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, we substitute here the words ose ha'shalom—adding the letter hei—to create a phrase which literally means "make the peace." The consequent word, ha'shalom, is comprised of five Hebrew letters totaling 381: hei equaling the numerical value of 5; shin equaling 300; lamed equaling 30; vav equaling 6; and mem equaling 40. The total, 381, is the same numerical value of the name of the angel Safriel, "the scribe of God." It thus evokes our wish to be subscribed and sealed for a sweet good year.*

📖 *Avinu Malkeinu - Father, Our King*

*Once in a time of great draught, the Talmudic sages decreed fast and public prayers, but to no avail—the rain did not fall. Then Rabbi Akiva came to lead the prayers, and he opened by saying, "Avinu Malkeinu, our Father, our King, we have no king but you." At once, his prayers were accepted and rain fell. (Tannit 25b) When the people saw that he was answered with this prayer, they added it to their supplications and petitions.*

Over time, many more short prayers beginning with the words *Avinu Malkeinu* were composed. The power of these words lies in the dual aspect of relating to our Creator—as a Father and as a King. A child calls his parent "father," even if his parent is the greatest of rulers. *Avinu* ("our father") is a cry, a yearning of a child for his father. *Malkeinu* ("our king") is the call of a servant to his king. Although the servant may have a very important position in the king's court, even that of a minister, there is always a measure of distance in the servant-king dynamics, which reflects the reality of our physical world.

Our souls are rooted in Divine oneness; we are truly a part of God above. As far as our souls are concerned, God is our Father, our Source of being. Our bodies, however, function in a universe of apparent separateness, a world of distance. On its own, the best that the body can feel is like a servant serving its master.

Both Father and King represent the "giver" in the relationship. We come to God as receivers of Divine blessings, and we plead, "listen to us from all levels of our reality." If we are more soul-oriented than body-oriented, have mercy on us and send us Your blessings, like a father who shows instinctive mercy on his children. But if the opposite is true, then please recognize our struggle and realize that, at the very least, we are like Your servants and our eyes are turned to You.

28. Page 110/152

אבינו מלכנו

Sing in Hebrew (not on Shabbos)



#### Opening of the Ark

Before we begin reading the Torah, we open the ark and recite a passage from the Zohar.

The Baal Shem Tov once said that when the ark is opened and we recite these words with purity, faith and from the depths of our heart, God will fulfill our requests, whether fully or in part. It is a time of extreme holiness, as the Alter Rebbe, R. Schneur Zalman, once said: "When the ark is opened, the world of the Ark of the Covenant of God is opened as well. Herein lies all the exertion and self-sacrifice invested in all the Torah scrolls that we have ever written. The angel Michael then proclaims, "God is in His holy sanctuary, let all the world fall silent before Him!" At this time, when we say this prayer from the depths of our heart, the angel Michael intercedes on our behalf."

29. Page 117/160

וידי

Sing in Hebrew



Adonai, Adonai, - When Moses prayed to God to forgive the Children of Israel's sin of the Golden Calf, God in response revealed His thirteen attributes of mercy. In the Talmud we read that God appeared to Moses as a Chazzan in a Tallit and said, "whenever Israel sins, let them carry out this service before Me and I will forgive them."

30. Page 117/160

ה' ה'

Sing in Hebrew



Beh Ana Rachitz, - These are the concluding lines of Brich Shmey, a prayer written in Aramaic, depicting God's mercy, praising him and extolling his goodness on behalf of the people of Israel. In the second

*century Rabbi Simeon stated that “when the Torah is removed to be read, the gates of mercy in heaven are opened and the attribute of God’s love is stirred up.”*

31. Page 117/160

ביה

*Sing in Hebrew*



*Torah Reading Day 1 – The first day's reading from the Torah, as well as the reading from the Prophets (known as the Haftarah), both concern stories of births to barren women. According to the Talmud, Sarah (whose story is recounted in the Book of Genesis) and Chana (whose story is recounted in the Book of Shmuel) both were remembered in heaven at this auspicious time, which is a cosmic time for birth and rebirth.*

*The reading of the Torah is called Kriat HaTorah, the word keriah meaning "to call out," as in one friend calling out to another. When we read the Torah, we call out to God and, thus, bring down the same energy that gives power to the verses we are reading.*

*Understandably, when we are listening to the Torah being read, we should do so with proper respect and an inner sense of awe. The reading, the calling out, draws down the Creator's blessings. As we read how God remembered Sarah and Chana, we evoke the same remembrance for ourselves, asking that God may remember us for goodness and blessing as well, and that on the day which is the birthday of the universe, new channels should open up, and it should be a year of revealed goodness.*

32. Page 126/174

מי שברך

*Recite in English (On Shabbos)*



*Reading from the Prophets – Day 1- On the first day of Rosh Hashanah, the Haftarah reading is from the book of Samuel. Similar to the Torah reading, after being barren for a long time, Chanah is remembered by God and gives birth to Samuel. This reading teaches us that sincere prayer can overcome difficulties and obstacles.*

33. Rosh Hashanah Sermon

34. Prayer for the United States of America / Prayer for Israel

35. Moment of Silence

## Rosh Hashanah Mussaf



*This prayer is called the “Amidah” the “standing” prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.*

*The Amidah is the central part of the service, it’s said every day of the year. Its divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.*

**Praise:** *The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.*

**Petition:** *The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.*

**Thanksgiving:** *Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.*

- |                     |       |                          |
|---------------------|-------|--------------------------|
| 1. Page 140/193     | מסוד  | <i>Recite in English</i> |
| 2. Page 140/194     | זכרנו | <i>Recite in English</i> |
| 3. Talking Point #3 |       |                          |

Over the years, a custom has developed that on Rosh Hashanah, during the course of the day, we go out to a living body of water with lively fish swimming therein and symbolically cast away our unwanted negative baggage. We take hold of our negativities, the devastating weight that presses us downward, and throw them into the waters. The act causes us to reflect inwardly, as we aspire to unburden ourselves of the negative elements within us and toss them into the waters to be covered over and washed away.

Rash Hashanah is a time of renewal, and in the new reality we are creating for ourselves, we wish to put aside the old self, perhaps forget about it and even throw it away. We reason that a radical shift in beingness is required. Most often, for something to change from what it is to what it desires to become there needs to be a moment when it ceases being what it is. A seed rots in the earth before it can offer new life; first comes sterility, then fertility. So we look at ourselves and look at the old image of the negative self and we let it go, let it slide into the waters.

A mere few days later, the festival of Sukkas comes around. In Temple times during the holiday of Sukkas, a festive celebration with ecstatic dancing and lively music took place as folks went to fetch water from the well to lubricate the Altar the following day. Though in the Torah there is a clear source, the sages intoned the verse that explicitly states, “You shall draw water with joy from the wells of salvation.”

This celebration was called “simchas beis hashueva- the joy of the drawing of the waters.” The joy was so immense and overwhelming that the sages of that time declared; “He who did not see the joy of simchas beis hashueva did not see joy in his life.” It was impossible for someone who has never experienced this celebration to truly appreciate what joy is all about. But why the joy? After all, it seems like a pretty simple, almost mundane act of drawing water.

The Rambam, Maimonides, seems to suggest that since with regard to the entire holiday of Sukkas the Torah says, “And you should be happy before Hashem your God for seven days” (Vayikra 23:40), and the soubriquet of Sukkas is “zeman simchaseinu – a time of our joy,” therefore, as a result of the overarching theme of joy during Sukkas, the joyfulness overflowed and inspired dancing and music during the fetching of the water.

Yet most commentators assume that there is an intrinsic relationship between gathering the waters and the ecstatic elation that was experienced and expressed.

While joy and happiness is our natural state, our ontological conditioning, often we lose touch with ourselves and we find ourselves down, dispirited and sad. To reclaim our birthright and to reattain our joy we need a stimulant. Often what evokes our joy is precisely the regaining of something that was lost. We all know the joy we sense when we are reunited with an old friend, when a person we love returns from a long trip, when spouses resolve a conflict, or for that matter when you lose your keys and then, after frantically searching, you find them. The joy comes from righting what is wrong, the sense of repairing the broken and making complete and whole that which has been shattered and fragmented. This is all part of the cosmic melding, the ‘two’ back into the ‘one.’

If in the initial stages of growth a radical brake is required, eventually a more drastic ingathering must take place. While during Rash Hashanah we cast aside the hindering elements of self in the waters, and that was beneficial and productive at that fragile stage, now we need a full embracing canopy, a Sukkah which will include all aspects of self. Now that a healthier self has emerged, there needs to be a reintegration of all aspects of who we are on this higher and deeper level. The joy is the reunification with our very own selves.

But how do we reintegrate and collect the old and broken parts of self? And what affords us the ability to do so?

A tear is a cleansing agent. The waters of our tears rinse out, purify and ultimately allows for full transformation to transpire. In between the two extremes of throwing into the water and gathering from the water are “the ten days of teshuvah.” In these honest days of introspection and deeply opening up, who is not moved to tears?

If you are aware and conscious of the times, and you open up and expose all of yourself to yourself and let it all come out, you will eventually find yourself crying. If not, says Ari R. Yitzchak Luria, “your soul is not complete.” Something is seriously amiss and drastically

misaligned. Paradoxically, this awareness itself of your lack of inspiration will catapult you and may even shake you out of your complacency and spiritual insensitivity. Either way, by the time we have reached the climax at the end of Yom Kippur, our tears have utterly inspired a total reorientation so that we can recollect and re-gather our lost parts and establish them within the new elevated context of our life.

Broadly speaking, there are two types of tears. There are the bitter tears of sadness, of loss and of yearning, but there are also the tears of joy and of reunification. Abraham cries when Sarah dies, but Jacob also cries when he first encounters his future wife Rachel.

During the days of teshuvah, culminating with Yom Kippur, the tears that flow are most often bitter tears of yearning, desiring to reunite, return and come closer. Once Sukkas comes about, the tears that may flow are tears of joy, of oneness and a healthy sense of reunification and belonging. Sitting in the Sukkah, we are present within the makifim of binah — the surrounding energies of divine comprehension. The walls are the makifim – surroundings, and sitting down, settling down, translates the bringing down of the transcendent within the immediate.

As we are sitting within the makifim of binah we are resting within the warming and gentle embrace of eima ila'ah – 'supernal mother.' Being engulfed within this sacred and protected space, we may feel overwhelmed to the point of tears, but here the tears are tears of joy, of a child returning and running back into the arms of his mother. After the arduous journey through Rash Hashanah and Yom Kippur we are finally home. We have arrived, and arrived with the totality of who we are.

☺ A Rabbi, known for his lengthy sermons, noticed a man get up and leave during the middle of his message. The man returned just before the conclusion of the service.

Afterward the Rabbi asked the man where he had gone." I went to get a haircut," was the reply. "But," said the Rabbi, "why didn't you do that before the service started?"

"Because," the gentleman said, "I didn't need one then."

📖 The moving prayer of "Unesaneh Tokef" is traditionally attributed to Rabbi Amnon of Mainz, Germany who was tortured terribly at the hands of the bishop of Mainz for staying true to Judaism and with his dying breath recited this prayer. Three days later he came to Rabbi Kalonymos ben Meshullam in a dream, taught him the words to the prayer and requested that he send it to all of Jewry and that it be inserted into the Rosh Hashanah liturgy. Rabbi Amnon's wish was carried out and soon it was also included in the Yom Kippur liturgy as well.

4. Page 144/200

ונתנה תוקף

Recite in English

5. 🎵 Page 144/200

כבקרת

TTO: אויפן פריפעטשוק

6. 🎵 Page 144/200

ובראש השנה

TTO: Carlebach ממקומך

7. Page 144/200 ותשובה *Recite in Hebrew*

8. Page 145/201 כתר *Recite in Hebrew*

9. Talking Point #4

After six months of working for the company, it's time for your evaluation. You walk into the boardroom, where three designer-suit-clad personnel managers are sitting behind a mahogany desk.

The one on the left scans your file, looks up at you accusingly, and says, "I see here that you did not report for work at 9 am one time during this entire period."

The woman in the middle shakes her head and remarks, "This is a Fortune 500 Company. Instead of a jacket and tie, you report for work wearing jeans."

The man on the right stares at the papers in his hand and says grimly, "Our surveillance cameras show that you spend less than 10% of your working hours at your desk. The rest of the time you're walking around the building."

The first evaluator shoots the question: "Do you have anything to say for yourself?"

"Yes," you reply with confidence, "I was hired as the night watchman."

Rosh Hashanah is a time of evaluation. But to accurately assess your performance this year, you have to know your job description. Judaism asserts that every soul comes into this world charged with a unique, positive purpose.

No one has ever or will ever come into this world with the exact same mission as yours. According to the great 16th century Kabbalistic master known as the Arizal, no one has ever or will ever come into this world with the exact same mission as yours. The light you are meant to shine into the world is yours alone, as individual as your fingerprint, as personal as your voiceprint.

Your mission can be interpersonal, such as counseling couples with troubled marriages, or scholarly, such as researching ancient Chinese culture, or an expression of your talent, such as painting landscapes or playing the violin. It can be concrete, such as establishing a home for Alzheimer's patients, or abstract, such as manifesting in the world the Divine attribute of truth or patience. It can be on a large scale, such as inaugurating the recycling system in your city, or on a small scale, such as caring for your handicapped child with joy. You may have two, or at most, three different missions, which can be consecutive (after finishing one job you start another) or simultaneous. Yet, even if there are 500 marriage counselors in your

city, your particular approach and way of helping people is unique. Not one of us can be replaced—ever.

Imagine you are an undercover agent sent into Iran. You've had years of training, have two vital contacts in Tehran, and are equipped with the latest hi-tech spy gadgetry. Only one thing is lacking: You have no idea what your mission is.

Many of us go through life like that: We follow the route laid out by society: going to college, finding a job, getting married, raising a family, but with no clear sense of the unique mission entrusted to us. We are pulled in many different directions, feeling compromised in what we do and guilty for what we don't do. Identifying our mission is the first step in leading a life of vibrancy and joy. When you intersect with your life's purpose you feel excitement.

Knowing your personal mission is essential preparation for Rosh Hashanah. On Rosh Hashanah God apportions to each of us life, health, livelihood, and everything else. What is your plan for how you propose to use the life God gives you? The CEO is not going to dole out a million-dollar budget to an employee who doesn't have a carefully worked out proposal.

We are used to praying for life, health, and livelihood as ends in themselves. In the Divine accounting, however, life, health, and livelihood are simply the tools – the hi-tech spy gadgetry – that will enable you to accomplish your mission.

There are two methods for discovering your mission:

- Ask yourself and write down: What were the five or ten most enjoyable moments in my life?
- Ask yourself: If I inherited a billion dollars and had six hours a day of discretionary time, what would I do with the time and money?

When answering the first question, eliminate the universal transcendent moments, such as witnessing the beauty of nature or listening to music. Your mission, of course, may have to do with nature or music, but on a much more individual level than the high all people feel when they see the Grand Canyon. Although your mission may require hard work or genuine sacrifice, when you are engaged in your life's mission you experience you feel that this is something I can do all day long.

The Creator has outfitted you with a unique set of aptitudes, talents, and interests perfectly suited to what you are charged with accomplishing. By following your inclinations and abilities, you may already have found your mission. Sometimes your mission is deposited in your lap, such as the birth of a special needs child. The National Tay-Sachs Association, for example, was founded by the parents of children suffering from Tay-Sachs; the parents' daunting challenge metamorphosed into their life's mission.

If your mission is not yet clear to you, take a half hour and reflect on, “What do I really want to do with my life?” Perhaps you work full time developing software for Microsoft, but you’ve always felt a tug to write a book about alcohol addiction. Perhaps your greatest pleasure is tending your vegetable garden in suburban Detroit, but you’ve always dreamed of living on an agricultural settlement in Israel. Such inner urges may be whisperings from God, the secret message from Headquarters disclosing your true mission.

Clarity about your mission dissipates guilt for all the worthy endeavors you’re NOT engaged in. Once you realize that you’re in this world to develop a new healing modality for autism, you won’t feel guilty that you’re not volunteering for the local soup kitchen or marching on the U.N. to protest anti-Israel discrimination.

The concept of each person having an individual life’s mission is a key to respecting other people. Otherwise, you may feel that what’s important to you should be important to everyone. You’re an environmental activist? You may blame your sister for being oblivious to the environment without appreciating that her mission is to fight Holocaust denial. You belong to a group that feeds the homeless? You may find it reprehensible that that other group is apparently heedless to the homeless and spends all their time in pro-Israel activism on campus. Being able to say, “This is my mission and that is theirs,” is the gateway to true tolerance and respect.

When the shofar sounds, be prepared to declare, “This is my job, and I’m working on it.” Knowing your individual mission validates your life and releases you from the pernicious habit of comparing yourself to others.

Jonah Salk’s mark on the world may seem as deep as a crater while you’re taking care of your handicapped brother may seem like a fingernail impression, but from a spiritual perspective the light you are shining into the world is unique and is exactly the light you came here to radiate.

One more point: Fulfilling your individual life’s mission does not exempt you from your global missions, such as supporting your family or raising your children. Starting an outreach center for the elderly may have to wait until your children are grown. Writing that book on addiction may have to be tucked into your few spare hours after your full-time job. Don’t worry. The God who assigned you your mission will make sure you have everything you need—including time now or later—to fulfill it.

So when the shofar sounds this Rosh Hashanah and you stand for your annual evaluation, be prepared to declare, “This is my job, and I’m working on it.”

☺ *Morris is determined to rid the company of all slackers. On his first tour of the factory, he sees a young man leaning against a wall. The area is full of production workers and he thinks this is a good time to let them all know he means business.*

*Morris walks up to the man and asks, "How much money do you make a week?"*

*The young man looks at Morris and replies, "I make \$240 a week. Why do you want to know?"*

*Morris then hands the man \$240 and shouts, "Here's a week's pay. Get out of here and don't let me see you here again."*

*Feeling pretty good about his first dismissal, Morris looks around and asks, "Does anyone want to tell me what that slacker did here?"*

*With a smile on his face, one of the workers replied, "He's a pizza delivery guy, who just delivered our lunch, and was waiting for his tip."*



*Aleinu – The insertion of this prayer at this point is to introduce the first of the three concepts of the Rosh Hashanah Amidah – Malchiyot (Kingship). We acknowledge that God is the supreme being and it is incumbent upon us to praise Him, the ruler of the entire universe. We then express our gratitude to Him for not making us like the other nations of the world.*

*During Aleinu, all men who are able kneel to the floor in commemoration of the kneeling that took place during the services at the Holy Temple.*

10. Page 149/207

עלינו כורעים

*Recite in Hebrew*

11. Page 155/213

שופר היום ארשת

*Recite in English* (ארשת is not recited on Shabbos)

12. Page 150/208

אוחילה

*Recite in English*



### Malchiyot - Kingliness:

*G-d is the incomparable King of The Universe. The destiny of humanity is to come to this realization. Whereas human kings rule in accordance with the principle of: "might makes right," G-d is the Holy King, Who is, at the same time, beyond comparison in His power, "Vas er vil, Tut er" - "Whatever He wills, He can do," yet He is also the Father of the orphan and the Judge of the widow, Who is always on the side of the powerless.*

*He is the Incorruptible and Righteous Judge of the World, Who favors no one, and cannot be bribed.*

*He is the true G-d and His word, the Torah, is true and eternal.*

13. Talking Point #5

## Pay Up Your Pledges

The Haftorah for the first day of Rosh Hashanah is the story of a woman named Chana who yearned for a child and, together with her husband Elkana, would annually make a pilgrimage to pray in the Tabernacle of Shiloh. Eventually she was blessed with a child, whom she named Shmuel because, "I borrowed him from God." The most well-known reason for designating this story as the Haftorah on Rosh Hashanah is that it was on Rosh Hashanah that God remembered Chana and made it possible for her to conceive (see Rosh Hashanah 11a).

One may, however, wonder, is this the only thing recorded in Scriptures which took place on Rosh Hashanah? For instance, it was on Rosh Hashanah that the prophet Elisha came to Shunam and blessed the woman with a child (see II Kings 4:8, and Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 597:1, Taz). It was also on Rosh Hashanah that the people gathered around Ezra to hear the Torah being read and resolved to follow its teachings. When the listeners wept because they realized that they had been neglecting the teachings of the Torah, Ezra and Nechemia told them not to be sad since it was Rosh Hashanah. "Go eat rich foods," they said, "and drink sweet beverages...for today is sacred to God" (see Nehemia, chap. 8).

Perhaps we can add another reason for specifically selecting the story of Chana to be read on Rosh Hashanah. Rosh Hashanah is a day when many come to shul and with a tremor in their heart, not knowing what the New Year entails for them. They make resolutions and even vows of loyalty to God and donations to charity, etc., hoping that in this merit their wishes will be granted and they will be blessed with a happy, healthy, and prosperous New Year. Unfortunately when the inspiration of the crisis disappears and when the danger is over, many pledges remain unredeemed and many vows are violated.

I am reminded of the story of the old woman who was about to walk across an old, rickety bridge. She said, "O G-d, if I get through safely, I will give one hundred dollars to charity." When she was a quarter of the way across and all seemed well, she said, "O G-d, I do not have so much. You won't mind, I know; fifty dollars are also enough." As she walked a little further, the bridge suddenly began to shake underneath her feet. "Oh," she said, "I only made a joke and G-d took me seriously."

Chana was a woman who was lacking fulfillment. She wanted very much to have a child of her own, and for years she came to the Tabernacle, poured out her heart, and beseeched God to grant her a son. Together with this she vowed, "If You will look upon the anguish of Your maidservant and give Your maidservant a male child, then I will give him to G-d all the days of his life." Finally her wish was granted, and when the boy was still very young, she brought him to the house of God in Shiloh. Though she could have procrastinated and waited till he became much older, claiming, "A young little boy needs the tender loving care of his mother," she did not look for excuses or loopholes, but made every effort to fulfill her pledge promptly.

This may be a reason for reading specifically about this event which took place on Rosh Hashanah. It is a reminder to all of us that when in the midst of our inspiration and fervent prayers we make resolutions, vows, and oaths to improve our relationship with God and man, we should remember to carry on tomorrow in accordance with the resolutions we have made today. Chana was blessed with an abundance of nachas and we, too, will be highly rewarded when we fulfill our promises.

😊 Abe is talking to his friend. *"If there's one piece of simple advice I can give you, Mervyn, it's this. I read it in the Times yesterday and it worked immediately for me.*

*I've finally found inner peace. I'm sure it will work for you too."*

*"So give me this advice, already," says Mervyn.*

*"OK, here it is," replies Abe, "the way to achieve inner peace is to finish all the things you've started."*

*"Really?" says Mervyn.*

*"Yes," replies Abe. "I looked around to see all the things I had started but hadn't finished. So, I finished one bottle of white wine, a bottle of red wine, a keg of beer, the bottle of whiskey, and a large box of gourmet chocolates. You have no idea how good I felt."*

14. Page 155/213

שופר\היום\ארשת

Recite in English (ארשת is not recited on Shabbos)



#### Zichronot - Remembrances

We recognize that Hashem is above Time, and the idea of "forgetting" does not apply to Him, nor is He limited in "understanding" the inner thoughts of His creatures. Nevertheless, we ask that He "remember" only the "good" in our behalf when He Judges us.

For all of humanity, for the whole world is Judged today, we ask that He "remember" the faith of Noach who endured taunts and threats for 120 years while he built the Ark, and tried to explain its purpose to his wayward generation.

For the Jewish People in particular, we ask that He "remember" the early loyalty of our People, who followed Him as a bride, as He said "I remember your youthful devotion, the love of your bridal days, how you followed Me through the desert, in a barren land" (Yirmiyahu 2:2) and later as a precious child, "Is it because Ephraim is my favorite son, my beloved child? As often as I speak of him, I remember him fondly. My heart yearns for him, I will have pity on him, says the L-rd." (Yirmiyahu 31:19)

Most of all, we ask that He "remember" the supreme act of devotion performed by our fathers Avraham and Yitzchak, where Avraham suppressed his natural feelings of mercy towards his son, and was prepared to sacrifice him at the command of G-d, and Yitzchak was prepared to be sacrificed, thereby suppressing his natural feelings of self-preservation, in fulfillment of G-d's command. So should G-d suppress, so to speak, His Midat HaDin, His Attribute of Strict Justice, which would require that we be punished for our misdeeds, in favor of His Midat HaRachamim, His Attribute of Mercy.

15. Talking Point #6

## The Shape of the Shofar

The shofar is narrow on one end and broad on the other. The broad end is where the horn was attached to the animal's head, and the narrow end is the tip of the horn. There are two rules in the Shulchan Aruch regarding the two ends of the shofar. One is that if someone mechanically changes the shape of the shofar by applying heat, making the narrow end wide and the wide end narrow, the shofar is pasul - disqualified - because the Torah states, "veha'avarta shofar teruah" - "you shall sound the blast of a teruah," and the word "veha'avarta" teaches that it must be "derech ha'avarato" - "in the same shape as when it was removed from the animal" (Orach Chaim 586:12).

Another halachah states that even when one does not make any physical changes in the shofar, but merely reverses it and blows through the wide end, he does not fulfill the mitzvah. A hint to this halachah is found in the pasuk, "min hameitzar karati Kah annani bamerchav Kah" - "from the straights [lit. narrow] I called to G-d, and then G-d answered me with expansiveness [lit. wide open]" (Psalms 118:5).

The first halachah is very easy to comprehend, but the second one is somewhat puzzling. To turn around a shofar and blow through the wide side, is extremely difficult. Why is one who exerts such effort and who delivers the prescribed tones rejected, receiving no credit for fulfilling the mitzvah?

When Bilaam was hired by Balak to curse the Jewish people, in amazement he said "Mah tovu ohalecha Yaakov mishkenotecha Yisrael" - "How goodly are your tents O Jacob, your dwelling places, O Israel" (Bamidbar 24:5). Rashi comments that Bilaam was amazed when "he saw that the openings [of their tents] were not lined up with the other." Why did he focus on their "openings"?

Rabbi Baruch of Mezibush, a grandson of the Ba'al Shem Tov, explains it in the following way. The Midrash Rabbah (Song of Songs 5:3) says that Hashem urges the Jewish people to do teshuvah, saying: "Pitchu li petach kechuda shel machat ve'Ani potei'ach lachem petachim shetiheyu agalot nichnasot bo" - "Make a small opening like that of the head of a needle, and I will open for you an opening through which caravans can enter." In other words, the Jew merely has to begin the teshuvah process, and Hashem will help him to attain the most lofty goals. Thus, the "openings" that Jews have to make and Hashem's reciprocal opening are not comparable.

Therefore, in praise and envy Bilaam said, "You Jews are so lucky; your opening and Hashem's opening are not 'lined up' - i.e. not identical - to each other. You only have to put in a little effort, and Hashem opens for you the vast gates of teshuvah. If your G-d loves you so much, how can my cursing possibly have an effect?"

The Rambam (Teshuvah 3:4) writes that though the sounding of the shofar on Rosh Hashanah is one of the six hundred and thirteen commandments of the Torah, it also conveys a call to the people to awaken from their slumber and do teshuvah - repent to Hashem.

It may be said that the two openings of the shofar, the narrow one and the wide one, represent the minute opening the Jew makes and the reciprocal broad opening of Hashem. While many may hesitate to do teshuvah, thinking that it is very difficult for one to return and come close to Hashem, the message of the shofar refutes this. It is simple to do teshuvah. Just make a small opening, move closer to Hashem, and He will open up His gates for you and facilitate your return.

The halachah about turning the shofar around and blowing through the narrow end is a metaphor for those who preach that teshuvah is difficult and that even if one goes through much effort he will accomplish very little in the end. This approach is contrary to our belief and, therefore, unacceptable and disqualified. The message conveyed by our way of blowing the shofar is that teshuvah is not difficult; a person simply has to make a small opening - a little effort, and he will reap immense reward.

☺ *It was graduation day and Mom was trying to take a picture of her son in a cap and gown, posed with his father. "Let's try to make this look natural" she said. "Junior, put your arm around your dad's shoulder."*

*The father answered, "If you want it to look natural, why not have him put his hand in my pocket?"*

16. Page 155/213

שופר היום ארשת

*Recite in English* (ארשת is not recited on Shabbos)

17. Page 150/208

אוחילה

*Recite in English*



### *Shofarot - Blasts of the Shofar*

*We recall the time that G-d revealed Himself on Mt. Sinai and gave us the Torah.*

*"The whole world trembled at Your Presence, Creation shook in awe before You, when You, our King, did reveal Yourself on Mt. Sinai to give to Your People the Torah and its Commandments, letting them hear your majestic voice, your holy words out of flashes of fire. Amid thunder and lightening did You reveal Yourself to them, amid the sound of the Shofar did you appear to them."*

*The Shofar will be blown during the final battles of Israel with its enemies.*

*It will be sounded when our Exiles return.*

*It will be sounded when the Temple will be rebuilt.*

*It is the sound signifying the Presence of the majesty of G-d.*

*We ask that it be sounded again with the arrival of the Mashiach.*

18. Page 159/217

אבינו מלכנו וכתוב

*Recite in English*



## Birkat Kohanim - Priestly Blessings & Prophetic Revelation

*There is a major difference between a prayer and a blessing. Although the two are related, they are not the same. The Hebrew for blessing is berachah, a word which shares its root with l'havrich, meaning "to join," or "to intertwine."*

*When a blessing is bestowed, what is accomplished is the joining of the source of blessing above with the person below. In effect, nothing new happens. The blessing merely activates the existing source of the blessing above and reveals it below.*

*By contrast, prayer awakens a new will. When people are ill and we pray for them, we recognize that there was a previous Divine will which brought about the illness, but we ask that now a new will should arise and bring health and revealed goodness.*

*Each have their merits. The blessing suggests a certain measure of guarantee in that it unveils that which is there, albeit in concealed potential. Prayer suggests no guarantee, but it has the power to create a new reality.*

*The Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) is unusual in that it contains both of these elements. It is a traditional blessing, arousing the above to manifest below, yet it is recited in the context of prayer, which gives the blessing an additional boon.*

*The power of the Priestly Blessing is to arouse new desires, create new realities and bring them forth in the hastiest of ways. The reason the Priestly Blessing can do so is because it does not originate with the priest, who after all is a finite, limited man; rather, it originates with God. The Priestly Blessing is a mitzvah, a Divine mandate, and as such its power is infinite and unrestricted. Not encumbered by the limitations of blessing in general, the Priestly Blessing can reach above and awaken the highest and newest Divine desires so that their effect is felt immediately below.*

*When the priests, who act as the conduits for Divine flow, pronounce the words of the Priestly Blessing with love, as commanded by the Torah, the Divine Presence rests on them. This is an opportune time for us to sweeten and annul all negative dreams and reinforce all the positive ones. Dreams usually project unconscious desires or bring forth incomplete thoughts, but there is also the possibility of a dream being one-sixtieth of prophecy. Such minor prophetic dreams are best annulled if they are bad, or, if they are good ones, reaffirmed at a time when the Divine Presence is most apparent.*

*During the Priestly Blessing, we should cover our eyes and face, so not to look at the priests which may cause a distraction, but also because at this time very high and intense levels of Divine energy and plenty are brought down.*

19. Page 160/

ברכת כהנים



## Hayom Timatzeinu- Confident Prayer

*As we reach the end of the prayers, we express the confident joy that God has accepted our prayers.*

*In general, prayers reflect two conflicting emotions—love/closeness and awe/distance. By definition, praying involves forging these two together, so they become one.*

*Certainly, at the outset, we may feel a sense of deep alienation and a great desire to move closer, but as we progress in prayer, a greater sense of closeness arises. Perhaps on all levels of prayer, there is a constant vacillation of emotions, but surely at the inception we feel more distance, while toward the end, we feel closer.*

*Having traveled on the path of prayer, and having arrived at the end of the musaf morning service, we confidently sing out our conviction of belief. This, in itself, ensures that our prayers will be answered for good, for blessings and for happiness.*

20. Page 161/220

ובספר חיים\היום תאמצנו

*Recite in English*

21. Page 162/245

אין כא-לוהינו

*Sing in Hebrew*



### *Aleinu - Closing the Prayers*

*According to the sages, Yehoshua composed this prayer upon entering the Holy Land. The great Kabbalist, Rabbi Yitzchak Luria, the Ari, writes that this prayer contains within it greater praise than the entire prayer service.*

*Aleinu secures the prayers so that none of the energy of our prayers become a source of anything unholy. For example, our elevated rapture does not evolve into anger.*

*Aleinu is more than prayer, as it also serves to help smooth the transition between prayer and our movement outward into the world. It assists us in rejoining the world, and that is why it is said at the end before we leave the synagogue.*

*Concluding prayers, we journey into the world with the recognition that "there is nothing else" besides Him. Realizing this allows us to see the hand of the Creator in every step we take, and as a result, our lives become more Godly and less mundane, more spiritual and less materialistic, and more profound and less petty.*

22. Page 164/247

עלינו

*Sing in Hebrew*

### 23. Announce Schedule:

- Tashlich will take place this afternoon at 5:30pm at the Japanese Gardens in Brand Park
- Services tonight at 7:30pm
- Tomorrow services begin at 10:00am. It is of utmost importance for all to attend services as we will be sounding the Shofar.
- Even if you cannot participate for the entire service – please make sure to come at 12:00noon to hear the Shofar



ב"ה

ראש

השנה

ה'תשע"ב

ספ

יום שני

## **Rosh Hashanah Shacharis**

### **Introduction to Rosh Hashanah Prayers**

Rosh Hashana, "The New Year" in Hebrew, is a deeply spiritual holiday. The New Year commemorates the creation of the world (Adam and Eve were created on Rosh Hashana) and each year the world's existence is extended for another year, created anew, as it were. Mankind is also included in this new creation every year.

The New Year is an obvious time for judgment (which is why Rosh Hashana is also called Yom HaDin, literally "Judgment Day"). Every creation we make, whether it is in art, business or even cooking, is judged by us. At some point we will step back and evaluate our creation. Does it live up to expectations? Are we pleased with it? What are its faults? On this, the anniversary of our creation, God does the same with us. We are evaluated, hence the "Day of Judgment".

This day is deeply spiritual because on judgment day, not unlike what happens when a person is waiting to hear a court sentence, we are forced to reflect on ourselves. Did I live up to God's expectation of me? Is God pleased with me? What are my faults? Because of the intense mood of the moment this day presents the most powerful spiritual opportunity available -- the opportunity for us to reflect on how we can elevate ourselves to a higher plane. What does God want from me? He wants me to be on His team. How am I judged? Have I lived my year pursuing self-gratification, or have I grown closer to God in thought and deed? Am I making this world a better place to live in?

This is the judgment on Rosh Hashana, these are the questions, and with this understanding the opportunities for spiritual growth are unparalleled. Dig in and enjoy the potential. Rosh Hashana is the spiritual world's prime time.

### **Lost in the Synagogue?**

The Rosh Hashana liturgy represents some of the most sublime and awesome words that have ever been penned to express our love and reverence for God. The theme of the day is making God a King. When we proclaim God as King we formally declare that we are His subjects and that we are at His service to do our part to help make the world a worthwhile creation. But getting into the deeply majestic liturgy is often not so easy. It is not unlike learning to appreciate fine wine or art. It takes time to appreciate rich elegance. Therefore we offer a few suggestions for overcoming possible boredom. Read the introductions and overviews presented in most Rosh Hashana prayer books. It's okay to not follow the services at all times and to do some independent learning and praying.

Use some of the time in shul for reflection and introspection. Tune in to the message of the day and try to meditate on it, letting it permeate your heart in the deepest and truest way. That may be more relevant for you than saying any particular paragraph.

While praying, focus on quality rather than quantity, on depth rather than breadth. Find a portion that you find relevant and meaningful, and say it slowly, thoughtfully. Three recommended portions would include the Shema prayer or Nishmas (just before Shachris Shema) and of course the core of the prayers, the Shemoneh Esrei or Amidah.. Savor the words as you say them, open your heart to their content and message. These are the high points of the service and might be just right for your personal meditations and concentration.

If the original Hebrew is not familiar to you, then have an English translation in the Kehot Machzor.

### Why is it so important to be here today in a Synagogue?

There is undoubtedly great reward for prayer even at home, but when one joins with the community in communal worship our prayers are especially cherished by God. For us, it establishes our dedication to the community and its values. Being together with fellow Jews on Rosh Hashana is its own reward. Maybe your grandchildren will remain Jewish because of your connection to the community.

### What about the Shofar?

The main theme of the day is brought out by the blowing of the shofar. The shofar is the royal trumpet we Jews blast to proclaim God's Kingship. Those blasts have the incredible ability to go deep into places in our psyche that are otherwise dormant and to awaken within them the natural desire to come close to God, to elevate Him, to develop a relationship with Him. The shofar trumpets our coronation of God and awakens our very spiritual essence to perform that job.

Rosh Hashana is a day packed with so much intense opportunity and spiritual promise. It is a day to be cherished. But it often takes some time to develop appreciation for its loftiness. That is why we should take it slow when getting into it at the beginning. Make it a point to focus your energies on a few good growth opportunities for the day and the coming year. In time these few items will become a real treasure trove. And it usually happens much quicker than you think!

1. Page 66/85

שיר למעלות

*Recite in English*



*Hodu - According to some Jewish Scholars this prayer is the oldest, continuously said, component of our daily prayers. It has been recited for some 3000 years by the Kohanim even before construction of the Temple, then subsequently by the general Jewish population and it was eventually incorporated into the Ashkenazik prayer book and then adopted by Sefardic Jews.*

*Hodu ("give thanks") is the official beginning of the "Verses of Praise," and it is here that we ascend to the second rung on the ladder of prayer. This second segment of the prayer corresponds in Kabbalah to the world*

of formation (yetzirah), and the level of soul known as ruach, which means "spirit" and signifies emotional consciousness.

*In this segment of prayer, we continually praise God for the revelation within nature and within history, for the wonders of creation, and for the miracles performed throughout the ages. These verses of praises were instituted for two primary reasons: first of all, to emulate the prayers of Moshe, who first praised God, then asked for his needs. By evoking Moshe's prayers, our own prayers are thus assisted. And secondly, by praising God, we are inspired and brought into the requisite state of joy.*

*Overall, this part of prayer is meant to be joyful and recited with an openness of heart. Whereas the word zimra is translated as "praise," it is also related to zemer meaning to "uproot/cut off." In these prayers, we cut away all our wrong desires and chip away at negativity. Yet, in so doing, we do not mean to expunge desire itself, rather to change its trajectory—that is, praise of God inspires a radical reorientation of our entire emotional reality.*

2. Page 68/87      הודו לה'      Sing in Hebrew

3. Page 69/89      האדרת      Sing in Hebrew



*Baruch Sheomar - this prayer is attributed to the men of the great assembly (Sanhedrin). According to tradition it was revealed from heaven with eighty seven words that correspond to the numerical value of the Hebrew word PAZ meaning "Refined Gold"*

*This blessing serves as an opening for the "Verses of Praise" (Pesukei De'Zimra). In the following passages of praise, we tell of the greatness of the Creator and the way He is manifest within creation, with the aim of arousing our emotions.*

*As an initiation to these verses, we recite "Blessed is He Who spoke..." (Baruch Sheamar), a prayer which expresses the wonder and awe of creation and how it is continually being recreated by Divine word.*

*Although creation had a beginning, it is continuous. God creates and recreates this world anew with each moment. This is an empowering thought to contemplate—that each moment gives us an opportunity to return to God in teshuvah, to start anew no matter what our previous errors were.*

*Thus, the first letters of the opening words Baruch Sheamar V'haya Ha'olam ("Blessed is He Who spoke and the world came into being")—beit, shin, vav, hei—spell out "return." We can only return to God through teshuvah if we are fully aware of the continuous renewal of creation. This gives us hope. If time would only flow linearly, then the past would inevitably dictate the present and future, and there would be no hope for us. But, when we are aware of the continuous flow of creation—that each moment represents a fresh beginning—we can pray with unimpaired joy.*

*Baruch Sheamar contains 87 words, which is the numerical value of the word paz, meaning "pure gold." As it says in Psalms (21:4): "You set on his head a crown of pure gold (paz)." This, then, is a prayer of the finest quality, and it is also the golden crown of the entire Pesukei De'Zimra.*

*The word baruch ("bless") appears thirteen times in this prayer. The number 13, the numerical value of echad (meaning "one"), inspires us to realize the oneness, uniformity and harmony within nature.*

During this prayer we gather together the two front fringes of our prayer shawl (tzitzit), an action which evokes the Source of all blessings, God. God's essential four-letter name—spelled yud, hei, vav, hei—has the numerical value of 26. Each corner fringe of the prayer shawl has 8 strings and 5 knots, adding up to 13, and when we gather the two front fringes together, we hold 26.

#### 4. Page 70/89

#### ברוך שאמר

#### Recite in English



*Mizmor Shir - Shabbat & Teshuvah - The Midrash tells us that following the brutal murder of his brother Hevel, Kayin was summoned to the heavenly tribunal for judgment. After a brief deliberation, it was decreed that Kayin would be condemned to a life of wandering: "You shall become a vagrant and wanderer on earth." Acknowledging the gravity of his iniquities and accepting his sentence, Kayin beseeched the court for mercy, asking, "Is my iniquity too great to be borne?"*

*Upon leaving the heavenly court, Kayin was met by Adam, his father. Seeing his son's jubilant disposition, Adam inquired of Kayin as to what had occurred in the court. When Kayin told him what he had done and that he had left the court with a clean slate, Adam said, "Such is the power of teshuvah, and I did not know it." He then began to sing "a Psalm, a Song for Shabbat day." The amazing transformative potential of teshuvah aroused Adam to compose a song in honor of the sacred day of Shabbat.*

*Shabbat and teshuvah are both similar in that they are both liberating agents. They spiritually free the human being from the normal course of unfolding reality. Shabbat exists as a refuge in time—no matter how absorbed we may be during the course of the week, we have a sacred time of refuge, when we are able to rest and reflect. Teshuvah is a refuge in place for the soul.*

*If we have drifted away from God and become alienated from the true source of our soul, teshuvah gives us a space where we can find refuge. In this space we can redefine and recreate our inner self and become reborn once again.*



*In Ashrei we find the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet encoded in the prayer. The first letter in each of the first 22 words is the alphabet in its correct order. Because the Hebrew letters are actual instruments of creation, this prayer helps to inject order and power into our lives. We can gain control over our world by tapping the forces that created it. Interestingly, the only letter left out of this prayer is the "nun". King David wisely left it out since nun has the same numeric value as the Hebrew word for falling... "noflim"... falling refers to a spiritual decline. Feelings of doubt, depression, worry, and uncertainty are consequences of spiritual falling.*

*"Happy are they who dwell in Your house and praise You continually..." From this verse (of Psalm 85:5), the Talmudic sages found support for the proper preparation for prayer: first settle the minds and then pray. First dwell in the home then offer praise. (Tosefos, Berachos 32b)*

*This introduction is then followed by Psalm 145. According to the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 4b), any individual who recites this Psalm three times daily is certain to experience the World to Come. For this reason it is included in the prayers three times, twice in the morning prayers, and once in the afternoon prayers.*

*By meditating on the meaning of its verses, we are assured of being strengthened in our belief and resolve, and because of that, we will inherit life in a future world.*

*This Psalm contains all the letters of the Hebrew alphabet except the letter nun, which is the first letter of nefilah, meaning "downfall" (as in the downfall of the nation of Israel) on a collective and individual level into the trap of worry, doubt, uncertainty.*

*Additionally, the nun refers to the mystery of the fallen Shechinah—the Presence of God, which is in exile now, as we read in the Book of Amos (9:11) "the canopy of David that is falling"—falling now. What we need to do is elevate the Shechinah, and bring about the unification between the higher spiritual world and the lower physical world.*

*This is why this Psalm opens with: "A Psalm of praise by David: I will elevate You," meaning "I will elevate/lift up the Shechinah." And this we do by offering praise to God.*

## 5. Talking Point #1

Every year at Rosh Hashanah, we stand in front of the Almighty and plead for another year. And every year, I'm tormented. What could I possibly say or do that would be enough? How much am I going to change? And haven't I made so many of these same commitments (unsuccessfully) in the past? Is my credibility completely torn to shreds?

What kind of a difference do I plan to make in the world in the upcoming year? Does it need to be global? Can it be local? How about just within my own family? How about just me? What can be enough to justify the tremendous gift of life? The torment continues...

But I know Rosh Hashanah is not supposed to be a day of torture. And I know the Almighty is a loving Father. So how do I reconcile these ideas?

I think "Father" is the key. I think about being a parent, about my own parenting and relationship with my children and how that applies here.

How many chances do I give my children to grow and change? LOTS. How many of us have said, "I'm going to count to 10 and then...9-1/4, 9-1/2, 9-3/4..." We are desperate not to have to punish our children. It is our absolute last resort, when there seems to be no other choice. Otherwise, whatever they do, we are willing to find a good reason, to be understanding, to judge them favorably – to believe in their ability to do it right the next time. Not only is the Almighty more compassionate than us, He sees much further. He sees options and opportunities we couldn't possibly conceive of. He gives us an almost infinite number of chances. We just need to appreciate and take advantage of them.

Additionally, what do we expect of our children? Certainly not perfection. We only want (or should only want) that they try their best, that they give it their all. If they do and the outcome is a C, I am satisfied. How could it be otherwise? I can't ask for more than they are capable of.

The Almighty's standards are not higher. Although He knows better what we are capable of and may, on occasion, push us to achieve our potential, He also knows that He controls the outcome. Our only grade is for effort.

And so our only job is to do our best. That eases the torment slightly – until I begin to contemplate what my best truly is. How much brain power is untapped? Do I really need all that sleep? If I ate a little healthier, would I have more energy? (Please tell me I can just continue to rely on coffee for that!) How many minutes or hours have I wasted? Was that conversation really an example of my higher self?

It turns out that doing our best isn't easy either. But the Almighty is our Father and our Creator. He believes in us and wants us to succeed. His most fervent desire is to grant us another year, another opportunity. We just need to start along the path. He'll meet us more than halfway. The torment eases some more...

😊 Abe was visiting Israel for the first time. As soon as his plane landed, he got a taxi to take him to his hotel.

The taxi driver was very friendly and told Abe all kinds of useful information.

Then Abe asks the driver, "Say, is Israel a healthy place?"

"Oh, yes, it really is," the driver answered, "When I first came here, I couldn't say even one simple word, I had hardly any hair on my head, I didn't have the energy to walk across a small room and I even had to be helped out of bed every day."

"That's a remarkable story, truly amazing," Abe said, "so how long have you been here in Israel?"

"I was born here."

📖 Nishmas – Our complete dependency on God is described in this moving and beautiful prayer. We again express praise and gratitude to God for all he has done for us. In this outpouring of praise we exclaim, "Were our mouths as full of song as the sea is of water and our tongues as full of joyous song as its multitude of waves..."

6. Page 77/97

נשמת

Recite in English

📖 Hamelech – The theme of Rosh Hashana is Kabbolas Ol, accepting upon ourselves God as our King. This acceptance is different than the daily acceptance of God being our creator. On a daily basis the kabbolas Ol functions as a foundation and beginning to our day, but the day itself is independent from its foundation. On Rosh Hashannah, the Kabbolas Ol is the essence of the day. Without it there is no day, and there is no foundation. – Lubavitcher Rebbe

7. Page 81/99

שוכן עד

Recite in English

📖 Yishtabach - there are 15 expressions of praises to G-d in this paragraph, similar to the 15 steps in the Temple in Jerusalem. Our relationship with God must be handled as we deal with life, one step at a time. Each

*step is a message that moulds and shapes our character. Similarly, our relationship with God is multifaceted, subtle, and sublime.*

*The verses of praise, Pesukei De'Zimra, began with a blessing (Baruch Sheamar) and concludes with a blessing (Yishtabach), even if this final blessing does not begin in the standard manner of "Blessed are You..." (Baruch Ata).*

*After singing God's praises for the wonders of continued creation and the miracle of the splitting of the sea, we conclude with the words, Yachid, Chei Ha'olamim, meaning "Unified, the Life of [all] the worlds."*

*There are two ways in which we speak of God as the life force. One is to say that God is Chei Ha'olamim and the other is Chai Ha'olamim. While both are translated in English as "Life of the worlds." In Hebrew, there is a subtle difference between the two. The word chei is a descriptive phrase, meaning "life of..." But the word chai is a noun, meaning "life." Thus, when it refers to God, chei denotes the "Life force of the world"—that light that is connected to, and permeates, this universe. Chai, on the other hand, denotes the light that is transcendent, hovering above the world.*

*Having explored nature and the miracles of nature, we come to an awareness that both the immanent light and the transcendent light are manifestations of one unified light, reflecting the finite and the infinite.*

8. Page 81/100

ישתבח

Recite in English



*Shir Hamaalos - written by King David, this prayer evokes forgiveness and supplication. It opens with "from the depth of my heart I call to you" – our prayers to God need to come from deep within; a service of the heart and soul*

9. Page 81/100

שיר המעלות

Recite in English



*Kaddish - In the prayer service, whenever there is a change between prayers, a break or movement, a special prayer called a kaddish ("sanctification" of the name of God) is recited in order to bring unity.*

*Whenever there is a separation in the prayers—or for that matter a "break" in life itself—we recite the Kaddish and declare, "Magnified and sanctified may His great name be..." Thus, we ensure that His name, the Source of all, is brought together in harmony, and a healing on all levels of existence takes place.*

*The essential four-letter name of God—spelled in Hebrew yud-hei-vav-hei—can be viewed as containing two parts. The first yud-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 15, represents the spiritual transcendence; the second vav-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 11, represents the physical immediate. This separation is the root cause of all dissension and separations, death included.*

*By reciting the Kaddish, "yisgadal veyiskadash," which contains eleven letters, we reunify the name and inspire a total reunification of the entire world.*

10. Page 82/101

ברכו

Recite in Hebrew



*Barchu - The Zohar teaches that "all things holy need summoning." And so the leader of the prayers begins with, "Bless God!," calling the entire congregation to bless God, adding, "Who is blessed" so as to include himself within the community. The congregation responds with, "Blessed be God," adding "Who is blessed forever and ever," implying that God is blessed by all—the lowly creatures and the heavenly, above and below.*

*The five Hebrew words of the response correspond to the five levels of soul, which become fully integrated by the reciting of the blessing.*

*We bend our knees and bow saying these words as we become open to God's blessings by humbling ourselves. The word for "bless" (barchu) shares its root with the word for "knee" (beirach), and so we bend our knees as we open ourselves to receive God's blessings.*

11. Page 85/104

קדוש – ברוך

Recite in Hebrew



*Ahavas Olam - Unity through Humility*

*Ahavas Olam is a prayer for unity. When we say, "bring us in peace from the four corners of the earth," we gather the four fringes (tzitzit) from the four corners of the prayer shawl (talit). In absolute reality, there is total unity, but in our world, there seems to be disharmony and division. There are corners/parts to the world. And so, we take the four fringes, which have 32 strings, and bring them together as one, holding them in the left hand and placing them against the heart for the reading of the Shema.*

*The number 32 denotes the paths of chochmah ("wisdom") and the idea of bitul ("self-nullification"), which open us up to a higher reality. By bringing the 32 strings together, we evoke the power of chochmah and the idea of bitul-ego abandonment, and through that, we bring peace, harmony, and unity to our own microcosmic world and to the macrocosmic world of which we are a part.*

*The talit together with its tzitzit embraces both unity and diversity. The multiplicity is represented by the fringes on the corners, but the fact that they are part of one garment represents the interconnectedness between all the apparent separate forces. Bringing the corners together as one, we are ready for the Shema—the quintessential statement of God's oneness.*

12. Page 86/104

אבינו – והאר

Sing in Hebrew



*The Shema is the ultimate expression of Divine unity. It declares not only that there is one God, but that there is nothing else other than God. God is one and the same as He was before and after the creation of the world, and all that exists is included within God.*

*The recitation of the Shema is commanded by the Torah, and ought to be done with complete and undivided attention since it expresses the basic principle of Torah—the belief in Divine oneness—and it speaks of the Creator's relationship with humanity and with our evolving history.*

*Generally, the Shema is said out loud with the right hand lightly covering the eyes, in order to block out any extraneous distractions, and to help us go inward.*

*The Shema, says the Talmud, should be recited in "the language you hear," meaning the language you "know." This mandate also suggests that whatever you hear—in everything and through everything that you hear—you should sense Divine oneness.*

*Two letters of the Shema are written extra large in a Torah scroll: the ayin, the last letter of the word Shema ("hear") and the dalet, the last letter of the word echad ("one"). Taken together, these two letters spell aid, meaning "witness." By reciting the Shema, we bear witness to the Creator's oneness.*

*When the final word, echad, is pronounced, it is drawn out, with each letter distinctly audible. These letters are: alef (which has the numerical value of 1), chet (8), dalet (4). Accordingly, when pronouncing these letters, we should think about the oneness of the Creator permeating the eight levels of creation (the seven heavens and the earth), and the four corners or four dimensions of the world, thus making ourselves aware that all dimensions, as well as time and space, are included in the unity of the Creator. There is also a custom among some when pronouncing echad to move the head slightly—right, left, forward, back, down and up—to indicate that the oneness of God permeates all directions of creation.*

*The Zohar mentions that when we pronounce the word echad, we should meditate on being willing to give up our life for God, even imagining ourselves being consumed by fire, thus sanctifying God's name.*

*Symbolically, when we cover our eyes, we are momentarily, technically blind, and as "the blind is akin to the dead," so the covering the eyes suggest a death of a sort—a rapture, a state of ecstasy, an expiration of the soul. In the words of Rabbi Eliezer Ezkari, it is as if "one died and is in front of the King."*

*In the opening statement of the Shema, plus the short statement that follows (Baruch Sheim), there are 49 letters, corresponding to the 49 gates of understanding, indicating that these passages of the Shema need to be absorbed intellectually, emotionally and ultimately factually.*

*It is customary to cover our eyes with our right hand while reciting the first verse, to promote deep concentration.*

13. Page 86/105

שמע

Recite in Hebrew

14. Page 89/108

מי כמוך

Sing in Hebrew



*This prayer is called the "Amidah" the "standing" prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.*

*The Amidah is the central part of the service, it's said every day of the year. It's divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.*

**Praise:** *The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.*

**Petition:** *The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.*

**Thanksgiving:** *Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.*

*The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two*

thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before God. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to God) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with God in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that Godliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

### Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter God's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) loud and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.



*Repetition of the Amidah – Remember us for life, King who desires life; inscribe us in the book of life, for our sake, O living God – four types of life. The word life is mentioned four times, corresponding to the four letters in God's most holy name, Yud, Hei, Vav and Hei. Additionally, these four repetitions of life correspond to the four spiritual worlds known as Atzilus (world of closeness), Briah (world of creation), Yezirah (world of formation) and Asiyah (world of action). Another four corrections are: this world, the world to come, the days of Mashiach and the resurrection of the dead. – Siddur HaRid*



*Zachreinu L'Chaim – During the recitation of the Amidah between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there are additions in the prayers.*

*This short addition called zahrienu or "remember us" contains the unholy number of eleven words signifying the eradication of forgetfulness. The holy number is ten, as in the Ten Sefirot (the ten spheres/channels of Divine energy through which God created the vessels of this world and which continue to permeate all existence).*

*In the holy (kedusha), there is a full integration of the Divine light within the vessels; however, in the unholy (kelipa), the Divine light does not fully permeate the vessel and remains detached and separate. Therefore, there are ten vessels plus the light, comprising the number eleven.*

*In the world of kedusha, which signifies full integration, there is no forgetfulness. In fact, there is no lapse of time, as all time is one unified whole. It is a world of no separation, and thus the past is as present as the future. It is only in the realm of kelipa, a world of separation and disunity, that the past becomes separate from the present and future, and there is forgetfulness.*

*Further on in Amidah, we continue with references to memory. Before "Who revives the dead," we add "Who is like You..." This short prayer contains eight words, as the number eight represents the transcendent—that which is above the natural cycle of created reality, represented by the number seven (as in the seven days of the week). Eight is beyond time. In recognition of this fact, the High Priest would also wear eight garments, thus unifying all time with the place of Divine mercy.*

## 17. Talking Point #2

### A Call From God

Rosh Hashanah is the anniversary of the creation of Adam, the first man. The Torah does not record what he did on his first day except for the account of how God took him and placed him in Gan Eden to work it and guard it, with explicit instructions not to eat from the Tree of Knowledge of good and evil.

The Torah relates that Adam and his wife Chava were both naked, and they were not ashamed. When, they violated God's command and ate from the tree of knowledge, the eyes of both of them were opened, and they realized they were naked, so they sewed together fig leaves and they made themselves aprons. Suddenly they heard the voice of God and they hid. God called out to the man and said to him, "Ayekah?" - "Where are you?" He replied, "I heard Your voice in the garden and I was afraid because I was naked, so I hid" (Bereishit 3:1-8).

This seemingly simple story is very enigmatic. While at times a person may allow himself to lie to his friend, no one would have the audacity to lie to God face to face! As you will recall, a moment ago we mentioned that when they realized they were naked they made themselves aprons. Now God is talking to Adam, who is dressed in his apron, and he tells God, "I hid because I was naked"?!

Man has been sent to this mundane and earthly world "to work it and guard it." It is incumbent upon him to study Torah and perform mitzvot and conduct his life in accordance to Torah instructions. For this he will ultimately merit a respected place in Gan Eden.

While some are faithful to their mission, unfortunately there are those who get side-tracked. The glitter of success blinds them into thinking that "I am a self-made man, a secure individual and have everything that is needed to assure myself the very best." Little by little man forgets about his dependence on God and begins to make for himself "garments" - security blankets which he is sure will protect him.

This is all good till one day he is awakened from his slumber by a "kol God" - "the voice of God." Suddenly, G-d forbid, he is taken to the hospital with a cardiac arrest or another serious ailment. Sometimes a catastrophe in his business shatters the entire security on which he confidently relied. At times it may be a tragedy in his family which casts him into gloom and despair. All these are the different forms of "kol God" - the voice of God calling man "Ayekah?" - "Where are you?" - wake up. At that time man realizes his nakedness without God. Everything he thought he had, all that he built and amassed, is really nil.

This is what also occurred with Adam. Living in Gan Eden and having everything available at his disposal, he "opened his eyes" and thought that he was secure and successful. Now he could do whatever he wanted, he thought, and not fear. When suddenly he heard a "call from God" he came to the realization how insignificant and "naked" he really was.

Hopefully no one should ever, G-d forbid, get "a call from heaven" to awaken him. May the call of the shofar of Rosh Hashanah be sufficient to bring us out of our slumber. Let us resolve on this day, happy, healthily, and in good spirit, to direct our lives according to the will of God.

☺ *Coach Epstein is having some trouble when coaching the Maccabi little league baseball team. At one point during a game, the coach says to one of the young players:*

*"Do you understand what a team is?" The little boy nods. Do you understand that what matters most is whether we win together as a team and also how we play the game?"*

*"Yes sir," answers the boy.*

*"So," Coach Epstein continues, "when a strike is called, or you're out at first, you don't argue and don't yell at the umpire. Do you understand all that?"*

*Again the little boy nods. "Yes, Coach, I understand" nervously he adds "but please sir, could you try explain that to my mother!"*

📖 *Atoh Hu -This alphabetically arranged piyut describes the power and sovereignty of God. Rosh Hashanah is dedicated to the proclamation that God is our King and He is righteous and fair, close to all who sincerely call on Him.*

|                    |            |                           |
|--------------------|------------|---------------------------|
| 18. Page 98/118    | אתה הוא    | <i>Recite in English</i>  |
| 19. 🎵 Page 98/118  | אתה הוא    | TTO: מזמור לדוד Carlebach |
| 20. 🎵 Page 98/118  | שמו מפארים | TTO: אדון עולם            |
| 21. 🎵 Page 99/119  | אדר והוד   | TTO: צור משלו             |
| 22. 🎵 Page 101/121 | מלך עליון  | TTO: אשת חיל              |
| 23. 🎵 Page 103/123 | כל שנאני   | TTO: אשרי                 |

 *Loeil Orech Din - This alphabetically arranged piyut is really a continuation of the previous piyut. It praises the attributes of God as He sits in judgment and is filled with forgiveness, compassion and mercy. Every first half-line ends with the words B'yom Din ("on the day of judgment") the other half-line ends with the word Badin ("with judgment"). The poem is changed with intense feeling, so that we can loudly and communally proclaim each of God's attributes.*

|                  |               |                          |
|------------------|---------------|--------------------------|
| 24. Page 105/126 | לא-ל עורך דין | <i>Recite in English</i> |
|------------------|---------------|--------------------------|

 *Kedusha – The children of Israel join the angels in praising God in this most significant part of the Cantor's repetition which is the sanctification of God's name in the highest heavens. In the book of Ezekiel we find that the angles who surround God keep their feet together when going before God. We do the same for this prayer.*

|                   |            |                          |
|-------------------|------------|--------------------------|
| 25. Page 106/126  | נקדישך     | <i>Recite in Hebrew</i>  |
| 26. Page 107/ 127 | אתה בחרתנו | <i>Sing in Hebrew</i>    |
| 27. Page 110/132  | ובספר חיים | <i>Recite in English</i> |

 *Oseh HA'Shalom - Before we conclude the Amidah we take three steps backward, taking the intense energy that was present during our prayers and bringing it down into this world—into the three levels of creation (beriah), formation (yetzira) and action (asiya). Thus, we integrate and tie up our prayers so that there is no nourishment for the unholy from this holy place of prayer. Occasionally, the intensity of a spiritual experience can spill over into unwanted directions, and so we need to make sure that there is no such thing happening here.*

*As we recite the words ose shalom ("make peace...") we bow to the right, left and center, bringing peace to the entire world.*

During the days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, we substitute here the words *ose ha'shalom*—adding the letter *hei*—to create a phrase which literally means "make the peace." The consequent word, *ha'shalom*, is comprised of five Hebrew letters totaling 381: *hei* equaling the numerical value of 5; *shin* equaling 300; *lamed* equaling 30; *vav* equaling 6; and *mem* equaling 40. The total, 381, is the same numerical value of the name of the angel *Safriel*, "the scribe of God." It thus evokes our wish to be subscribed and sealed for a sweet good year.



### *Avinu Malkeinu - Father, Our King*

Once in a time of great draught, the Talmudic sages decreed fast and public prayers, but to no avail—the rain did not fall. Then Rabbi Akiva came to lead the prayers, and he opened by saying, "Avinu Malkeinu, our Father, our King, we have no king but you." At once, his prayers were accepted and rain fell. (Tannit 25b) When the people saw that he was answered with this prayer, they added it to their supplications and petitions.

Over time, many more short prayers beginning with the words *Avinu Malkeinu* were composed. The power of these words lies in the dual aspect of relating to our Creator—as a Father and as a King. A child calls his parent "father," even if his parent is the greatest of rulers. *Avinu* ("our father") is a cry, a yearning of a child for his father. *Malkeinu* ("our king") is the call of a servant to his king. Although the servant may have a very important position in the king's court, even that of a minister, there is always a measure of distance in the servant-king dynamics, which reflects the reality of our physical world.

Our souls are rooted in Divine oneness; we are truly a part of God above. As far as our souls are concerned, God is our Father, our Source of being. Our bodies, however, function in a universe of apparent separateness, a world of distance. On its own, the best that the body can feel is like a servant serving its master.

Both Father and King represent the "giver" in the relationship. We come to God as receivers of Divine blessings, and we plead, "listen to us from all levels of our reality." If we are more soul-oriented than body-oriented, have mercy on us and send us Your blessings, like a father who shows instinctive mercy on his children. But if the opposite is true, then please recognize our struggle and realize that, at the very least, we are like Your servants and our eyes are turned to You.

28. Page 110/152

אבינו מלכנו

*Sing in Hebrew*



### *Opening of the Ark*

Before we begin reading the Torah, we open the ark and recite a passage from the Zohar.

The Baal Shem Tov once said that when the ark is opened and we recite these words with purity, faith and from the depths of our heart, God will fulfill our requests, whether fully or in part. It is a time of extreme holiness, as the Alter Rebbe, R. Schneur Zalman, once said: "When the ark is opened, the world of the Ark of the Covenant of God is opened as well. Herein lies all the exertion and self-sacrifice invested in all the Torah scrolls that we have ever written. The angel Michael then proclaims, "God is in His holy sanctuary, let all the world fall silent before Him!" At this time, when we say this prayer from the depths of our heart, the angel Michael intercedes on our behalf."



*Adonai, Adonai, - When Moses prayed to God to forgive the Children of Israel's sin of the Golden Calf, God in response revealed His thirteen attributes of mercy. In the Talmud we read that God appeared to Moses as a Chazzan in a Tallit and said, "whenever Israel sins, let them carry out this service before Me and I will forgive them."*



*Beh Ana Rachitz, - These are the concluding lines of Brich Shmey, a prayer written in Aramaic, depicting God's mercy, praising him and extolling his goodness on behalf of the people of Israel. In the second century Rabbi Simeon stated that "when the Torah is removed to be read, the gates of mercy in heaven are opened and the attribute of God's love is stirred up."*



*Torah Reading Day 2 – The general purpose of the second day's readings, both of the Torah and the Haftarah, is to draw on the merits of our ancestors. The Torah reading concerns the offering of Yitzchak by Avraham, which according to the Zohar occurred on Rosh Hashanah; by reading this portion of the Torah, coupled with the blowing of the shofar, we evoke the merits of these patriarchs.*

*The Haftarah also speaks of the merits of the people of Israel. The selection from the Book of Yermiyahu quotes God as saying, "Is Ephraim not My beloved son, is he not a precious child that whenever I speak of him I recall him even more?."*

*When we read these verses, we draw on the merits of our ancestors for blessing and for protection, and even more importantly, for strength to reach their levels of spirituality. Yitzchak's self-surrender stands out in that he was the first to pass a test of such magnitude, and, thus, he opened the path for generations to come to attain similar heights. By reading this Torah portion, we are empowering ourselves, so that in the new year our actions will be founded on such dedication and commitment.*



*Reading from the Prophets – Day 1- On the first day of Rosh Hashanah, the Haftarah reading is from the book of Samuel. Similar to the Torah reading, after being barren for a long time, Chanah is remembered by God and gives birth to Samuel. This reading teaches us that sincere prayer can overcome difficulties and obstacles.*



*In this powerful chapter of Psalms, the name of God, Elokim, appears seven times. Elokim is the screen that shields the receiver from the infinite overwhelming light of God, expressed in the essential four-letter name, the Tetragrammaton, which is spelled in Hebrew yud-hei-vav-hei, and which we are forbidden to pronounce. This essential name of God represents the infinite, while Elokim represents the finite, the Divine energy that is en clothed within restrictions of time and space. When we recite this name the seven times, we pierce the seven heavens and overcome the seven levels of veils, and from our narrow, constricted, finite place—reflected in the narrow mouthpiece of the shofar—we extend into a wide, vast place of the Infinite light.*

### **Koli Shima**

*Taking the first letters of these verses, we spell out kra Satan (rip apart Satan).*

*Satan is nothing more than a concealment of the Divine. It is the power of kelipa, which translates in our own life as uncertainties, doubts, and the inability to see our Divine purpose. In its grasp, we perceive life as random, giving rise to even greater confusion and covering over the Divine life force within us. But when we rip apart the kelipa, we realize what it is a shell. The kelipa is a mirage—when we peel it away, there is nothing there.*

*The sound of the shofar blasts open a cosmic opening in the restricted place of kelipa, allowing Divine energy to flow into this world and into our lives.*

### **Min Ha'metzar**

*"From the depths I call out to you, and You answer me with expansiveness." This is the theme of the shofar—a simple cry from the deepest parts of our soul, penetrating all worlds and inspiring a renewed and expanded desire for God to create and assume kingship.*

36. Page 127/175

למנצח־מן המצר

*Recite in English*

37. Page 128/175

תקיעות

38. Page 128/175

אשרי־בשמך־כי תפארת *Recite in English*

## Rosh Hashanah Mussaf



*This prayer is called the “Amidah” the “standing” prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.*

*The Amidah is the central part of the service, it's said every day of the year. Its divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.*

**Praise:** *The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.*

**Petition:** *The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.*

**Thanksgiving:** *Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.*

- |                 |       |                   |
|-----------------|-------|-------------------|
| 1. Page 140/193 | מסוד  | Recite in English |
| 2. Page 140/194 | זכרנו | Recite in English |



*Jonathan has a terrible toothache and goes to see Arnold, his dentist. After looking at the tooth, Arnold says, "I'm sorry to have to tell you this, but the tooth is badly decayed and can't be saved. It will have to come out." "Oy vay," says Jonathan, "how much is it going to cost me?" "For you," replies Arnold, "only \$125." "That's rather a high charge just for maybe 5 minutes work," says Jonathan. "Well," replies Arnold, "if that's how you calculate the cost of high quality dental work, I can always extract it much slower for you."*



*The moving prayer of “Unesaneh Tokef” is traditionally attributed to Rabbi Amnon of Mainz, Germany who was tortured terribly at the hands of the bishop of Mainz for staying true to Judaism and with his dying breath recited this prayer. Three days later he came to Rabbi Kalonymos ben Meshullam in a dream, taught him the words to the prayer and requested that he send it to all of Jewry and that it be inserted into the Rosh Hashanah liturgy. Rabbi Amnon's wish was carried out and soon it was also included in the Yom Kippur liturgy as well.*

- |                     |            |                       |
|---------------------|------------|-----------------------|
| 3. Page 144/200     | ונתנה תוקף | Recite in English     |
| 4. 🎵 Page 144/200   | כבקרת      | TTO: אויפן פריפעטשוק  |
| 5. 🎵 Page 144/200   | ובראש השנה | TTO: Carlebach ממקומך |
| 6. Page 144/200     | ותשובה     | Recite in Hebrew      |
| 7. Page 145/201     | כתר        | Recite in Hebrew      |
| 8. Talking Point #3 |            |                       |

## Asking Versus Wanting

From the beginning of the month of Elul until Hosha'ana Rabbah we recite twice daily the 27th Chapter of Psalms, in which King David says, "Achat sha'alti mei'eit Hashem oto avakeish" - "One thing I ask of the G-d that is also which I desire."

While on the surface, it appears to be repetitious, the truth is that King David is teaching us a lesson of cardinal importance concerning our communication, via prayer, to Hashem.

Unfortunately sometimes the things which "sha'alti" - "we ask for" - and "avakeish" - "what we desire and strive for" - are not really "achat" - "one," i.e. identical. King David is proclaiming, "that which I ask for" and "that which I want and desire" are "achat" - identical. You may wonder, is there anyone who is foolish enough to pray for one thing and work to defeat his own prayers? The answer is "yes." Permit me to cite some examples.

Throughout the year, we pray for good health and for a tranquil life. After our prayers, we plunge into the grind of work and worry, in which our physical health and nervous system get an awful beating. Thus, the "sha'alti" - "what we asked for" - is not complemented by the "avakeish" - "our desires."

We pray "Our G-d, Our Father, return us to You in full repentance." Can we honestly say that we want Hashem to grant this prayer? Do we seriously intend to alter our ways and outlook and really do teshuvah? Is the "avakeish" compatible with "sha'alti"?

We pray for the speedy redemption of our people and that Mashiach bring us to our Holy land. But are we really ready for Mashiach? Do we seriously want to give up our pseudo-security and our comforts to follow Mashiach to our Holy Land?

In the olden days there were tzaddikim who took self-imposed exile upon themselves. They would travel from city to city and not reveal their identity. Once, such a tzaddik spent a night in an inn which belonged to a Jew who was totally alienated from Yiddishkeit. At midnight, the tzaddik began to recite the prayer of Chatzot. He sat on the floor with candles around him and wept over the destruction of the Beit Hamikdash, praying for Mashiach and the rebuilding of the Beit Hamikdash. The innkeeper, hearing cries, traced them to the room of the tzaddik. With his pass-key he opened the door and beholding the strange scene asked, "What is wrong? Why are you crying? Are you not feeling well?" The tzaddik explained that he was crying over the destruction of the Beit Hamikdash and praying for the speedy revelation of Mashiach. With the assurance that his guest was not ill, the innkeeper went back to sleep.

In the morning, he related to his elderly mother the strange episode he witnessed the night before. His mother who happened to know about Yiddishkeit but had become estranged,

instructed him to go to the tzaddik and ask him to suspend his prayers for Mashiach for three weeks because there was a three week's supply of lard in the barrel which she did not want to have to throw out.

Unfortunately, there are many who verbally pray for Mashiach without really being ready to give up their attachments to behaviors and lifestyles which may not be entirely "kosher."

So you see, dear friends, sometimes we say prayers without consciously putting an ear to what we are saying. Let us strive during these days of prayer and teshuvah, to be earnest in the requests which we place before Hashem and not only "sha'alti" - "ask of Hashem" - but also "avakeish" - "desire and strive" to change our daily life for the better.



*Aleinu – The insertion of this prayer at this point is to introduce the first of the three concepts of the Rosh Hashanah Amidah – Malchiyot (Kingship). We acknowledge that God is the supreme being and it is incumbent upon us to praise Him, the ruler of the entire universe. We then express our gratitude to Him for not making us like the other nations of the world.*

*During Aleinu, The chazzan kneels to the floor as a commemoration of the kneeling that took place during the service in the days that our Holy Temple stood.*

- |                  |                |                          |
|------------------|----------------|--------------------------|
| 9. Page 149/207  | עלינו\כורעים   | <i>Recite in Hebrew</i>  |
| 10. Page 155/213 | שופר\היום\ארשת | <i>Recite in English</i> |
| 11. Page 150/208 | אוחילה         | <i>Recite in English</i> |



#### Malchiyot - Kingliness:

*G-d is the incomparable King of The Universe. The destiny of humanity is to come to this realization. Whereas human kings rule in accordance with the principle of: "might makes right," G-d is the Holy King, Who is, at the same time, beyond comparison in His power, "Vas er vil, Tut er" - "Whatever He wills, He can do," yet He is also the Father of the orphan and the Judge of the widow, Who is always on the side of the powerless.*

*He is the Incorruptible and Righteous Judge of the World, Who favors no one, and cannot be bribed.*

*He is the true G-d and His word, the Torah, is true and eternal.*

- |                  |                |                          |
|------------------|----------------|--------------------------|
| 12. Page 155/213 | שופר\היום\ארשת | <i>Recite in English</i> |
| 13. Page 150/208 | אוחילה         | <i>Recite in English</i> |



#### Zichronot - Remembrances

*We recognize that Hashem is above Time, and the idea of "forgetting" does not apply to Him, nor is He limited in "understanding" the inner thoughts of His creatures. Nevertheless, we ask that He "remember" only the "good" in our behalf when He Judges us.*

*For all of humanity, for the whole world is Judged today, we ask that He "remember" the faith of Noach who endured taunts and threats for 120 years while he built the Ark, and tried to explain its purpose to his wayward generation.*

*For the Jewish People in particular, we ask that He "remember" the early loyalty of our People, who followed Him as a bride, as He said "I remember your youthful devotion, the love of your bridal days, how you followed Me through the desert, in a barren land" (Yirmiyahu 2:2) and later as a precious child, "Is it because Ephraim is my favorite son, my beloved child? As often as I speak of him, I remember him fondly. My heart yearns for him, I will have pity on him, says the L-rd." (Yirmiyahu 31:19)*

*Most of all, we ask that He "remember" the supreme act of devotion performed by our fathers Avraham and Yitzchak, where Avraham suppressed his natural feelings of mercy towards his son, and was prepared to sacrifice him at the command of G-d, and Yitzchak was prepared to be sacrificed, thereby suppressing his natural feelings of self-preservation, in fulfillment of G-d's command. So should G-d suppress, so to speak, His Midat HaDin , His Attribute of Strict Justice, which would require that we be punished for our misdeeds, in favor of His Midat HaRachamim , His Attribute of Mercy.*

#### 14. Talking Point #4

##### "No Deposit No Return"

When a Jewish boy reaches the age of thirteen and celebrates his Bar-Mitzvah, it is customary for him to receive gifts. The most popular gift, of course, is a check, but others also receive books and other valuable items. When Jack became Bar-Mitzvah he was eagerly awaiting the gift that his grandfather, a wealthy man and noted philanthropist, would give him. After the celebration, he came home and began to unpack the gifts.

His grandfather's gift came in a box. Inside on the top was an envelope with a handsome check. As he dug down deeper, he found an old-fashioned glass bottle of Coca Cola. On it was a note from his grandfather telling him that the bottle carried an important message for him to remember all the days of his life and that it would be his key to great success.

Unable to decipher the message, he waited till the morning when he went to his grandfather's home, thanked him for the nice check, and then asked, "What was I to learn from the bottle?" The grandfather gently told Jack, "Nowadays in most cities when you buy a bottle of soda you pay a deposit, which you receive back when you return the bottle. Etched in the glass of this old bottle that I gave you, are the words, 'no deposit no return,' and it is a beautiful message which you should always remember. In life, if one expects a 'return,' it is necessary to make a 'deposit.'"

"Miracles do happen, but only from time to time and only to certain people. To sit idle and wait for them to happen is improper. It is necessary to do, to put in one's best effort, and undoubtedly Hashem will bless one with happy returns. This is true in every facet of life.

"When one experiences difficulty in a marriage, it is necessary to explore if the husband and wife really made a 'deposit' and gave of themselves to each other. When a partnership in business goes sour, one should examine if each partner really made honest deposits - earnestly devoted himself, his time, and his interest to the business. If one is disappointed with the way his children are turning out, he should ask himself, 'Is it their fault or is it mine? Did I deposit into them an education and appreciation of Yiddishkeit which would produce the returns I would like to see now?' "

Rosh Hashanah is the time of the year when one makes resolutions, but resolutions in themselves are meaningless and insufficient. A resolution must be supported with sincere efforts. First and foremost, we must not forget that "no deposit, no return." One cannot sit back and just rely on a miracle. It is up to us to put forth the effort and make the deposit, and when we do, the return is usually well worth it.

15. Page 155/213      שופר\היום\ארשת      *Recite in English*

16. Page 150/208      אוחילה      *Recite in English*



#### *Shofarot - Blasts of the Shofar*

*We recall the time that G-d revealed Himself on Mt. Sinai and gave us the Torah.*

*"The whole world trembled at Your Presence, Creation shook in awe before You, when You, our King, did reveal Yourself on Mt. Sinai to give to Your People the Torah and its Commandments, letting them hear your majestic voice, your holy words out of flashes of fire. Amid thunder and lightening did You reveal Yourself to them, amid the sound of the Shofar did you appear to them."*

*The Shofar will be blown during the final battles of Israel with its enemies.*

*It will be sounded when our Exiles return.*

*It will be sounded when the Temple will be rebuilt.*

*It is the sound signifying the Presence of the majesty of G-d.*

*We ask that it be sounded again with the arrival of the Mashiach.*



*When the air raid siren went off in Tel Aviv, Hannah rushed down the stairs toward the basement of their apartment block. Isaac was much slower so she stopped and shouted back up the stairs, "Come on, Isaac, get moving will you?"*

*Isaac shouted down to her, "Wait a minute, Hannah. I'm looking for my teeth." "Never mind your silly teeth, Isaac," Hannah shouted back, "what do you think they'll drop on us - smoked salmon bagels?"*

17. Talking Point #5

## **The Potential of the Individual**

In six days the A-mighty created the heaven, earth, and its inhabitants. According to the sages, creation commenced on the 25th day of Elul and six days later, Adam, the first man was created (see Vayikra Rabbah 29:1).

Rosh Hashanah commemorates the creation of Adam, the first man and the ancestor of humanity. Accordingly, this singular anniversary was designated to serve as the perennial day of judgment for Adam's descendants throughout the generations. On this day it is incumbent upon Adam's children to reflect and contemplate whether man, as evolved throughout history, has justified and vindicated the hopes and aspirations of his Creator.

One of the main distinguishing features in the creation of man is that he was created single, unlike all other species, which were created in large numbers. This indicates emphatically that one single individual has the capacity to bring the whole of creation to fulfillment. Adam, following his creation, single-handedly rallied all creatures in the world to recognize the Sovereignty of the Creator. When Adam was created, all creatures who saw him were gripped with fear and bowed to him in mistaken belief, that he, Adam, had created them. Adam said to them, "Do not think I created you. 'Come, let us worship and bow down before Hashem our Maker'" (Psalms 95:6) (see Pirkei D'Rabbi Eliezer 11).

Adam, the first man, was the prototype and example for every individual to follow. Every Jew, regardless of his time, place, and personal status, has the capacity to rise and attain the highest degree of fulfillment and also elevate the entire creation.

Rosh Hashanah - the anniversary of the first human - disproves the contention of those who sit idle and follow the tide, with the excuse that it is impossible for one person to change the world or pattern of society. Many of us give up when it comes to introducing more Yiddishkeit in our neighborhood, in our children's homes, or even in our own lives. We do this saying, "es iz farfalen, men ken garnit tan" - "It is a lost case, nothing can be done about it."

The message of Rosh Hashanah is that each and every Jew has tremendous potential, and with sincere efforts he can improve and elevate himself, his family, society, and even the entire world.

☺ *A few weeks ago, the story goes, a Pakistani Jew met Osama bin Laden at the tailor.*

*"How are you doing," the Jew asked bin Laden.*

*"I am fine, but I am very nervous. The US is zooming in on me. I am afraid to die."*

*"But why?" asked the Jew. "In your philosophy, you will go straight to paradise, Osama. With the amount of infidels you killed, you will have not 72 slices of pizza waiting for you-but myriads of pizza pies waiting to give you pleasure. You should be happy to die."*

"I am afraid," Osama said, "that I might die on the wrong day. The day of death in Islam is very significant. It determines your fate in heaven. And I do not know which day the Americans will choose to kill me."

"Do not worry," said the Jew. "I promise you, you will die on a Jewish holiday."

"That's wonderful," said Osama with a sigh of relief. "That's the best day to die on. Jewish holidays are holy days. But tell me, how do you know? How do you know I will die on a Jewish holiday?"

And the Jew responded to Osama bin Laden:

"Any day you die on, Mr. bin Laden, will become a Jewish holiday!"



### *Birkat Kohanim - Priestly Blessings & Prophetic Revelation*

There is a major difference between a prayer and a blessing. Although the two are related, they are not the same. The Hebrew for blessing is *berachah*, a word which shares its root with *l'havrich*, meaning "to join," or "to intertwine."

When a blessing is bestowed, what is accomplished is the joining of the source of blessing above with the person below. In effect, nothing new happens. The blessing merely activates the existing source of the blessing above and reveals it below.

By contrast, prayer awakens a new will. When people are ill and we pray for them, we recognize that there was a previous Divine will which brought about the illness, but we ask that now a new will should arise and bring health and revealed goodness.

Each has their merits. The blessing suggests a certain measure of guarantee in that it unveils that which is there, albeit in concealed potential. Prayer suggests no guarantee, but it has the power to create a new reality.

The Priestly Blessing (*Birkat Kohanim*) is unusual in that it contains both of these elements. It is a traditional blessing, arousing the above to manifest below, yet it is recited in the context of prayer, which gives the blessing an additional boon.

The power of the Priestly Blessing is to arouse new desires, create new realities and bring them forth in the hastiest of ways. The reason the Priestly Blessing can do so is because it does not originate with the priest, who after all is a finite, limited man; rather, it originates with God. The Priestly Blessing is a *mitzvah*, a Divine mandate, and as such its power is infinite and unrestricted. Not encumbered by the limitations of blessing in general, the Priestly Blessing can reach above and awaken the highest and newest Divine desires so that their effect is felt immediately below.

When the priests, who act as the conduits for Divine flow, pronounce the words of the Priestly Blessing with love, as commanded by the Torah, the Divine Presence rests on them. This is an opportune time for us to sweeten and annul all negative dreams and reinforce all the positive ones. Dreams usually project unconscious desires or bring forth incomplete thoughts, but there is also the possibility of a dream being one-sixtieth of prophecy. Such minor prophetic dreams are best annulled if they are bad, or, if they are good ones, reaffirmed at a time when the Divine Presence is most apparent.

During the Priestly Blessing, we should cover our eyes and face, so not to look at the priests which may cause a distraction, but also because at this time very high and intense levels of Divine energy and plenty are brought down.

19. Page 160/

ברכת כהנים



### Hayom Timatzeinu- Confident Prayer

As we reach the end of the prayers, we express the confident joy that God has accepted our prayers.

In general, prayers reflect two conflicting emotions—love/closeness and awe/distance. By definition, praying involves forging these two together, so they become one.

Certainly, at the outset, we may feel a sense of deep alienation and a great desire to move closer, but as we progress in prayer, a greater sense of closeness arises. Perhaps on all levels of prayer, there is a constant vacillation of emotions, but surely at the inception we feel more distance, while toward the end, we feel closer.

Having traveled on the path of prayer, and having arrived at the end of the musaf morning service, we confidently sing out our conviction of belief. This, in itself, ensures that our prayers will be answered for good, for blessings and for happiness.

20. Page 161/220

ובספר חיים והיום תאמצנו

Recite in English

21. Page 162/245

אין כא-לוהינו

Sing in Hebrew



### Aleinu - Closing the Prayers

According to the sages, Yehoshua composed this prayer upon entering the Holy Land. The great Kabbalist, Rabbi Yitzchak Luria, the Ari, writes that this prayer contains within it greater praise than the entire prayer service.

Aleinu secures the prayers so that none of the energy of our prayers become a source of anything unholy. For example, our elevated rapture does not evolve into anger.

Aleinu is more than prayer, as it also serves to help smooth the transition between prayer and our movement outward into the world. It assists us in rejoining the world, and that is why it is said at the end before we leave the synagogue.

Concluding prayers, we journey into the world with the recognition that "there is nothing else" besides Him. Realizing this allows us to see the hand of the Creator in every step we take, and as a result, our lives become more Godly and less mundane, more spiritual and less materialistic, and more profound and less petty.

22. Page 164/247

עלינו

Sing in Hebrew

## 23. Announcements

- Shabbat is this evening, light candles at 6:21 pm
- Yom Kippur begins in a week from tonight. Kol Nidrei begins at 7:00pm
- Yom Kippur day services are one week from tomorrow and begin at 10:00am